

The Cracks
Beneath the Surface

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The Cracks Beneath the Surface

*Unmasking the Lies, Confronting the Pain,
and Finding God in the Midst of It All*

by Christopher Kelly

Dedication

For my mother—

From my earliest days, you fought for me in ways I couldn't understand.

You carried my name before God when I was too lost to even speak it myself.

Your faith became the quiet force that stood between me and the grave more times than I can count.

I know there were nights when tears soaked your pillow, when hope felt thin, and when my choices must have broken your heart.

Still, you never stopped believing that God could reach me, even when all the evidence said otherwise.

You taught me what it means to stand in the gap, to pray without ceasing, and to love without conditions. Even when I pushed you away, you stood firm. Even when I was blind to it, you were planting seeds that would one day take root.

The grace that has transformed my life is a reflection of the grace you showed me every single day. This story—my story—is also yours. Because without your prayers, your strength, and your unshakable faith, I would not be here to tell it.

“Grace didn’t find me
polished.
It found me in pieces.”

Foreword

Some time ago, my friend Chris told me he was writing a book. Instantly, my curiosity was sparked. What would be the driving force behind his story, I wondered? Having known Chris for nearly a decade, I had already seen his love for writing—it was evident from the start. I knew he had the ability, drive, and vision to create something worth reading. What I didn't know was which audience he would choose to reach. So, I waited patiently.

I knew the book would be autobiographical, but I was eager to see how he would deliver it. From the very first page, I was hooked by its clarity and gripped by its raw honesty. Chris paints vivid pictures for the imagination without overwhelming the reader. Seeing my friend pour out his heart—not just to make sense of his own experiences, but also to reflect the struggles of so many others—is a noble task. In these pages, we see how broken lives can be put back together. The book doesn't shy away from hard truths or difficult questions, but it seeks to do so with integrity and a clear conscience.

As my former coworker, brother, and good friend, Chris and I have spent years talking, debating, and challenging each other's views on life. Reading his book feels like a continuation of those moments—times when we sought truth no matter how difficult it was to face. This book provides insights and answers to questions too often left unspoken. Beyond his personal experiences, it will make you reflect on your own—your past struggles, your shortcomings, and your need for God's help.

Though backgrounds may differ, people from all walks of life will find themselves in these pages. And like Chris, we are all invited to look to God's grace—the only power strong enough to transform a life into one worth living.

Preface

This book is not just a story about my past—it's a journey through the cracks where the light broke in.

For most of my life, I believed the lie that my worth was defined by my worst mistakes. I lived in a cycle of destruction, addiction, and rebellion, convinced I was beyond repair. It took twenty-seven years behind prison walls, the sudden collapse of everything I thought I controlled, and an encounter with the living God to finally see the truth: I was not beyond His reach, and I never had been.

The Cracks Beneath the Surface was born out of that realization. It is my honest account of the road that brought me here—from childhood wounds that hardened into survival, to the choices that led me deeper into darkness, and the moments where hope fought its way back in. These pages hold the raw, unfiltered truth: the shame, the loss, the anger, the moments I'd rather forget—and the grace that met me anyway.

I wrote this book because I believe stories have the power to set others free. If you are wrestling with your past, if you feel trapped in patterns you can't break, if you've ever wondered whether God could love someone like you—this book is for you.

It is not a manual. It is not a sermon. It is my life, laid bare, in the hope that the cracks you carry will one day be filled with the same light that broke through mine.

—Chris K.

Acknowledgments

First and foremost, I give thanks to my Lord and Savior, Jesus Christ. Without Him, this book would not exist, and neither would the man I've become. He was my strength when I had none, my patience when I wanted to give up, and my rock when the storms came. Every step of my journey — from the darkest nights in a prison cell to the freedom I now walk in — is a testament to His mercy, grace, and unfailing love.

To my mother — your strength and faith through the years have been a living example of perseverance. I've watched you endure more than most could bear, and yet you never wavered in your belief that God could reach even me. Your prayers, your love, and your unshakable trust in Him carried me when I couldn't carry myself.

To Tina — you are more than an answered prayer. You have stood beside me not just in the victories, but in the hard days when the weight of the past felt heavy. Your love, work ethic, and shared vision for our future have shown me what partnership truly means. I thank God daily for bringing you into my life, and I'm grateful to be building something meaningful with you by my side.

To Chris and Mike — you both showed me what real transformation looks like. The peace I saw in you was something I didn't

think could exist in prison, and it made me curious about the God you served. You planted seeds in my life that changed everything.

To Smitty — thank you for your friendship, your wisdom, and the way you stood with me as I stepped away from the destructive lifestyle that had marked my life for so long.

To the many men who walked alongside me in those pivotal years — your support, encouragement, and honest conversations gave me a vision of who I could become. You taught me that brotherhood rooted in truth is far more powerful than any false loyalty the yard had to offer.

To my family — thank you for loving me at my worst and never giving up. Your support showed me God's mercy and grace in a way that words can't fully express.

To those who challenged me, confronted me, and refused to let me hide in my nonsense — you gave me the accountability I had lacked for most of my life. At the time, I didn't always appreciate it, but looking back, I know it was love in its truest form.

This book is as much yours as it is mine. Every page carries the fingerprints of the people who believed in me when I couldn't believe in myself. You are living proof that God uses people to accomplish His work — and my story is simply one example of what He can do when grace meets a willing heart.

Author's Note

This book is my truth.

The events, conversations, and experiences in these pages come from my own memories, journals, and lived moments. Some names and identifying details have been changed to protect the privacy of individuals, but the heart of every story remains as it happened.

I did not write this to glorify the life I once lived, but to show the deep cost of it—and the even deeper grace that pulled me out. You will read about violence, addiction, betrayal, and loss, because those were real parts of my journey. But you will also see moments where God's presence broke through the darkness, even when I didn't recognize Him.

I am not the hero of this story. The hero is the One who found me at my worst and made me new. My hope is that as you turn these pages, you will not only see my scars, but also the fingerprints of the God who heals.

This is not just my story—it is a testament to what's possible for any life, no matter how far gone it seems.

Prologue: The First Night

The first night in juvenile hall wasn't what I had imagined, not that I had imagined it at all. When the cold steel doors slammed shut behind me, it wasn't just the sound of a cell locking; it was the sound of my life ending, as I knew it.

Everything up to this point had been a blur – the flashing police lights, the tightness of the handcuffs, the voices of officers saying things I couldn't process. But now? Now, I was alone. Just me, the walls, and the silence that pressed in on me harder than any set of chains.

Nothing felt real. Just hours ago, I was free. I had been in my own home, walking through my own front door, able to move wherever I pleased. I could have gone outside, laid in my bed, shut out the world if I wanted to. Now, I was trapped inside this cold, windowless building; inside this tiny cell, no bigger than a bathroom. And the walls felt like they were closing in. I tried to ignore it, to tell myself this was temporary. But deep down, I knew the truth. I wasn't going home – not tonight; maybe not ever.

I sat on the stiff mattress, staring at the cracks in the ceiling.

Is this really happening? Am I really here? I replayed the night in my head, over and over, trying to make sense of how I had ended up in this place, at this moment.

Then came the voices, the ones inside my own mind. *You did this. There's no going back. This is your life now.*

I wasn't crying; I couldn't. I had learned a long time ago that tears didn't solve anything. But deep inside, there was a fear that I couldn't escape. *What happens next? How long will I be here? What will they do to me?* I squeezed my fists, my nails digging into my palms, trying to ground myself, trying to keep myself from falling apart. But the weight of it all was crushing me.

The lights in the hallway never went out. Even when I closed my eyes, I could still feel them, still feel the reality of where I was... and sleep never came. How could it? I was trapped in a nightmare I couldn't wake up from. And the worst part? This was just the beginning.

The silence and the solitude forced me inward. I couldn't stop the memories from resurfacing, couldn't escape the whispers of a past that had shaped me; the ones that had quietly broken me long before this night. Lying there, staring at the cracked ceiling, I finally started to understand.

The cracks had been forming long before I ended up here.

Chapter 1: Haunted Echoes

I was sixteen, lying in a bunk in juvenile hall, but I had felt trapped long before I did the unthinkable; long before my deep fall into drugs, alcohol, and doing as I pleased.

Now, here I was with the cold concrete walls pressing in around me. Sleep wasn't coming; my mind wouldn't let it. Every time I closed my eyes, the weight of everything pressed down harder. The sound of the cell door locking echoed in my head, like a cruel reminder that this wasn't a dream. It was my new reality.

My mind kept repeating over and over – *How did I get here?*

The obvious answer was the night of the crime. The deeper answer? That started long before. Long before the sirens, before the handcuffs, before I sat in that interrogation room under those fluorescent lights, trying to hold my own against men who already knew the truth. It started as a kid, years ago, in a home that looked normal from the outside but had cracks running beneath the surface – cracks no one talked about.

People say childhood shapes you. I never understood what that meant until now – lying here, realizing I had spent my entire life reacting to things I never had control over.

I wasn't born broken. But the cracks started early.

Chapter 2: Voices of the Past

I can still hear the voices – my parents' voices. Sharp, raised, cutting through the walls like they were made of paper. Their fights were like the weather – unpredictable but constant. Some days were fine, some weren't. I learned early on to tell the difference, to listen to the tone of my father's voice when he walked through the door, to watch my mother's movements, to know when a storm was coming.

The cycle had stages.

First came the peace – the moments that made me believe, maybe this time would be different. The laughter at dinner, the days at the river, the weekends at Stardust Roller Rink when my sister and I could escape, gliding across the floor under flashing lights, pretending we were anywhere else.

Then came the tension – the harsh words between them, the looks, the heavy silence that filled the house like a weight no one wanted to acknowledge. Then, the explosion – the shouting, the slamming doors, the words that cut deep even when they weren't meant for me.

And then, the worst part – the silence after. That was the part that killed me.

Because it meant everything would go back to "normal", like nothing had happened. No apologies, no explanations, just another layer of pain stacked onto a house already full of it.

And me? I just had to exist in it. I had to pretend it wasn't happening, pretend I wasn't affected, pretend that I was okay. But I wasn't okay.

I felt as though my voice didn't matter. I could scream and beg them to stop but they wouldn't. How could the people who were supposed to love and protect me cause so much confusion and pain? No matter how much it hurt to watch, I was powerless.

So, I stopped trying. I stopped feeling. I stopped believing in anything outside of survival.

I felt that was what my home taught me – that love was something unpredictable, something that could turn on you at any moment. Strength wasn't about talking things out; it was about who could yell the loudest, who could hold their ground the longest, and who could hurt the other person more.

I didn't realize it then, but I was becoming like them. When you are in an environment like that, you begin to normalize the behaviors around you and think they are acceptable. I was learning that control came through force, that power came from fear, and that to be heard, you had to *make* people listen.

I used to think that what happened to me as a kid didn't matter. I was my own person, made my own choices, and that I had been in control this whole time.

But I wasn't.

I had been following a script that was written for me, before I even knew how to read. I was repeating the cycle without knowing I was part of it.

Thinking of all this, I turned onto my side, pulling the thin blanket over me, but it didn't make the cold go away.

I thought about my Father – about how I had spent my whole childhood trying to prove something to him. Always trying to be tough and strong; trying to be everything I thought a man was supposed to be.

But what was a man supposed to be? I didn't know. It seemed the only thing I had ever really been taught was how to survive and that lesson had led me straight here.

Back to a cage. Back to silence. Back to the only thing I had ever known.

Lying in this cell, I can see it all so clearly now. I can see the moments that shaped every decision, every reaction, and every outcome.

Chapter 3: Unshackled Memories

As I laid there on my cold bunk trying to sleep, I thought back to happier times, like when my sister and I would go to the Stardust Roller Rink. It was more than just a building with flashing lights and a wooden floor – it was an escape – a world where the past and future didn't matter; only the rush of movement, the steady beat of the music, and the feeling of freedom that came with gliding effortlessly across the rink.

I can still hear the click-clack of wheels against the polished floor, the laughter of kids racing past, the flashing neon lights reflecting in the glossy surface, and the smell of buttered popcorn mixed with the faint scent of sweat. For a few hours, every worry and every burden I carried, faded into the background. It was just me, the music, and the rhythm of my skates.

My sister and I were different in so many ways. She was the good one – the one who did everything right, the one who never got in trouble, the one who seemed to know how to navigate the world while I was just trying to survive it.

Despite our differences, there were moments when none of that mattered. When we were just two kids, lost in the same rhythm, sharing the same space, bound by something stronger than blood, there was the unspoken understanding that no matter what happened, we still had each other.

She was older, wiser, and more responsible. Where I was reckless, she was careful. Where I chased validation from my friends, she chased her dreams. And though I didn't always show it, I admired her. Even when I felt like I was falling apart – like I was losing myself to the chaos at home – she was steady and focused. She knew who she was, and that both inspired and frustrated me.

Stardust was one of the places where I felt closest to her. We didn't have to talk about the things that were happening at home. We didn't have to acknowledge the fights, the tension, the weight that sat heavy in the air every time we stepped through the front door.

Out there on the rink, life made sense. It was simple. You moved, you glided, you let go.

I was always chasing something – speed, excitement, a rush that never lasted. I'd push the limits, seeing how fast I could go, how sharp I could turn, how many people I could weave through without falling. I lived for the thrill and that feeling of being in control when everything else felt out of control.

She, on the other hand, skated with grace. She wasn't reckless like me. She moved with precision, effortlessly navigating the rink while I zigzagged past, barely missing a collision.

Sometimes she'd roll her eyes at my antics, telling me to slow down, to stop trying to impress everyone. Other times, she'd laugh, shake her head, and race me – knowing full well she could win – if she wanted to.

There were moments when I wished I could be more like her, but deep down, I felt like I was already too far gone. She and I would eventually take different paths – hers filled with

discipline, achievement, and a drive to rise above, while mine veered into rebellion, destruction, and eventually – prison walls.

But at Stardust, none of that mattered. At Stardust, we were just kids.

It's not in the grand gestures or the perfect words. It's not always loud or obvious. Sometimes, love is just showing up. It's lacing up your skates, stepping onto the rink, and choosing to move forward.

And maybe that's what saved me – small moments like that.

Chapter 4: Echoes of Validation

My childhood wasn't all chaos. There was not only Stardust; there was also my curiosity. Stardust was one kind of refuge and my curiosity was another kind.

There were the mornings when I'd step outside and leave the noise behind – the yelling, the tension, the weight that lived inside those walls. Once my feet hit the pavement, something in me shifted. I wasn't just walking to school. I was exploring.

Sometimes, I took the long way to school. Sometimes, I found shortcuts – ducking through alleyways, hopping fences, cutting across empty lots just to see where they led. It was my first taste of freedom, although I didn't think of it that way back then. I just knew I loved being outside. I loved the cool morning air and the way the sun cast long shadows as it rose. Freedom – Movement – Discovery – Escape. I was chasing peace in every small way I could find.

When I rode my bike, it was even better – the feeling of my legs burning after pedaling up a hill, knowing the downhill ride would be worth it. The thrill of speeding down that hill with the wind against my face and the sound of my tires crunching against dirt and gravel – those were the moments I felt most alive.

School wasn't just a destination; it was also an escape. A new adventure began as soon as I walked through the school

gates. At school, I was a different kind of explorer. I wasn't just navigating the hallways; I was navigating something deeper.

A need to be seen. A need to be heard.

I was smart. I got my work done quickly, usually before anyone else. But once I was finished, I got restless. The classroom wasn't enough to hold my energy, my need for attention, or my craving for validation. So, I acted out. I became the class clown.

I cracked jokes, made kids laugh, did things I wasn't supposed to just to get a reaction. The laughter was addictive. The attention I got from my classmates fulfilled something inside me that I didn't even know was empty. For those few moments, I was the center of everything, and I liked that feeling. But it came with a price.

I can't count how many times I ended up in the principal's office, staring at the clock, waiting for my parents to come pick me up because I was being suspended. It became a routine – act out, get in trouble, face the consequences. But to me, the consequences were worth it. At school, at least, I was getting some kind of attention. At home, I was just a kid caught in the crossfire.

My parents were not happy about my suspensions. I can still remember the look on my mother's face, the way her brows furrowed, the frustration in her voice as she tried to keep herself composed.

And then there was my dad. He didn't keep himself composed. When he came to get me, I knew exactly what was coming. The lecture – the yelling – the punishment – the paddle.

He would tell me how embarrassing it was for him to have to come get me, that I was acting like a fool, how I needed to be better, to be smarter, to know when to shut up. And then came the paddle and the grounding. A month-long restriction. No TV, no playing outside, no friends.

But the punishments never lasted. By the next day, he'd let me off restriction; probably not wanting to deal with me. That led to fights between him and my mom. She thought I needed discipline and he didn't care enough to follow through.

To me, that sent a message. It put in my mind that I could get away with things. And in the classroom – making my classmates laugh, getting them to notice me, to acknowledge me – that was worth any punishment.

My mom handled things differently. She was softer, more patient. But even she had her limits. I could see the exhaustion in her eyes, the way she tried so hard to keep everything together, to make sense of things that didn't make sense. She wanted to understand me, but I don't think she knew how.

She tried, though. She would sit me down and talk to me in a calm voice, asking me why I kept getting in trouble. But I never had an answer for her. How could I tell her the truth? That I acted out because I didn't know how to make things better at home; that I was trying to distract myself from the things I couldn't control; that I loved the feeling of being noticed.

I didn't have the words for all that back then. So, I just shrugged, stared at the floor, and waited for her to give up. Eventually, she always did.

The hardest part of growing up were the contradictions. My parents would tell me not to do something, only to turn around and do it themselves. They told me to be respectful, but I watched my dad curse and drink and fight with my mom.

How was I supposed to make sense of that? How could I take their rules seriously when they didn't even follow them? It was confusing, frustrating, and it made me question everything.

So, I stopped trying to follow the rules and followed something else – the laughter, the acceptance, the validation. Because at the end of the day, getting in trouble didn't bother me as much as being ignored.

Even now, looking back, I can see how much that need for attention shaped me. It wasn't just about making people laugh. It was about proving I existed. It was about finding a place where I mattered and that feeling never really went away. It followed me into my teenage years. It followed me into the streets. It followed me into the choices I made – the risks, the fights, the lies, the crime.

Eventually, it followed me into prison.

But back then, I didn't know any of that. I was just a kid, walking to school, making my own path – sometimes taking the long way and sometimes searching for shortcuts. I was just a boy in a classroom, cracking jokes, chasing laughs, and hoping someone would see me.

I just wanted to belong.

Chapter 5: Diamonds and Dreams

There were other places where the chaos didn't reach. Places where I wasn't a kid caught in the middle of fights; where I wasn't just another mouth to feed or another source of stress for my parents. Places where I felt free.

Stardust Roller Rink was one of them and the baseball field was another. It was a place where everything disappeared, at least for a little while.

Baseball was more than a sport to me; it was strategy, competition, and precision – a game where everything made sense. Unlike my home life, baseball had rules. If you worked hard, if you practiced, if you put in the effort, you got better. Simple. Predictable. Fair.

And I was good at it.

When I stepped onto the field, I wasn't the kid who got in trouble at school or who didn't know where he fit in at home; I was a ballplayer. I loved the strategy of the game, the way every play mattered, the way I could read a pitcher, anticipate a steal, or make a diving catch.

I watched baseball on TV, memorized stats, and knew the numbers by heart. Every morning, I'd wake up early just so I could grab the newspaper and read the box scores while crouched on my haunches – something my mom always warned would ruin my knees.

Of course, I didn't listen and now I wish I had. She was right about a lot of things. But back then, I wasn't thinking about my future. I was thinking about the game. The rush of stealing a base, the satisfaction of making solid contact with the ball, the way a good play could electrify the team.

The baseball field was the one place where my dad and I connected. He was hard on me – not just as a father but as a coach. He pushed me, yelled when I made mistakes, and expected perfection.

At the time, I didn't understand why and I thought, no matter how hard I tried, I wasn't good enough. I didn't know that was just his way of showing he cared. I didn't know he had his own demons and his own struggles. We didn't talk about those things. The cracks beneath the surface were never acknowledged.

Looking back, I realize how much I was always searching. Searching for an escape, for approval, for something that felt steady, something that wouldn't change. I found pieces of that in baseball, at Stardust, in my friendships with John and Tim.

I could skate around the cracks in my world, run the bases and pretend they weren't beneath me, lose myself in friendships, distractions, and fleeting moments of normalcy. But they were still there.

And eventually, my life I would fall right through them.

Chapter 6: Sunshine and Shadows

There was one other place where I felt like I could truly breathe – the river. Summers at the Colorado River were some of my happiest times. The river was our sanctuary and our place of refuge from everything waiting for us back home. The river was where we felt like a family.

Mornings on the river were my favorite. The air was still cool, the water smooth as glass, waiting to be disturbed by the first boat cutting through its surface.

My dad would be up early, checking the ropes, making sure the boat was ready, a cigarette in one hand and a cup of coffee in the other. He took pride in those trips – in the boat, the gear, and that he could teach me how to ski and how to handle myself on the water.

There was a peace in those early mornings; a kind of stillness that didn't exist anywhere else in my life. I would sit by the water's edge, digging my feet into the warm sand, listening to the occasional splash of a fish breaking the surface.

The air smelled like sunscreen and gasoline as the boats revved up for the day. It was a smell I came to love, because it meant freedom – freedom from the tension, the shouting, and the feeling of walking on eggshells at home.

I loved the thrill of skiing across the river, the wind whipping my face as I held onto the rope, my arms straining against the pull of the boat.

My dad's voice would carry over the roar of the engine, calling out instructions. "Bend your knees!" "Stay balanced!" And when I got it just right and managed to glide across the water without wiping out, his approval was unmistakable.

Sometimes, friends or other families were there too, bringing their jet skis and I'd watch, itching for a turn. When I got the chance to ride as a passenger or take one for a spin, it was like flying – cutting through the water, twisting the throttle, feeling the spray hit my skin. It was a different kind of rush, a taste of freedom, control, and pushing limits just to see how far I could go.

But the river wasn't just about the thrill; it was about the feeling those summers gave me. It was the time of year when my parents seemed to laugh more, argue less, and enjoy each other's company.

My mom made sure we had everything we needed – snacks packed, sunscreen applied, life jackets zipped. My dad steered the boat, making sure everything ran smoothly, teaching me the right way to cut across the wake.

I remember watching my dad at the helm, his face relaxed; a contentment I didn't see often at home. Out here, he wasn't the man who slammed doors and raised his voice.

He was in his element – calm, in control, and present. I lived for those moments when he'd call me "Bud" and ruffle my hair; when I could pretend that things were always this good.

Even Mom seemed lighter at the river. She would stretch out on the boat, her sunglasses on, letting the sun warm her skin. I used to wonder what she was thinking about in those moments – if she was enjoying the peace as much as I was, or if she was already bracing herself for when we had to pack up and go home.

When we weren't on the water, we were playing along the riverbanks. My sister and I would collect rocks, build little sandcastles, and wade out as far as we dared. The hot sun made the sand unbearable to walk on barefoot, and we'd race each other to the shade – laughing, daring each other to see who could last the longest.

Nights at the river were something special too. When the heat of the day finally gave way and the sky turned that deep, dark blue, we'd sit around a fire, listening to the distant hum of boat motors still out on the water.

The stars were always brighter at the river, uninhibited by city lights. I'd stare up at them – mesmerized – feeling like the world was so much bigger than the one I knew.

Those summers made me feel like I truly belonged in the world. But even here, the cracks sometimes showed. My dad – never far from his cooler of beer – would sometimes drink too much. When that happened, the tension crept back in, quiet at first but unmistakable. His words would slur, his movements were slower, and I'd watch my mom's face shift, her shoulders tensing, her eyes losing their light.

Small arguments that built into something big would leave Mom shaking her head as my Dad stormed off. Those moments shattered my illusion that our river trips were a safe place – that we were different out here.

When the tension would rise, I had one way out. I would run.

I'd take off down the shore, pushing my legs as hard as they could go, letting the wind dry the sweat on my skin. The sand shifted beneath my feet and the water lapped at the shore beside me, but I didn't stop. I ran until my lungs burned, until the shouting faded behind me, until I could believe, just for a little while longer, that the river could wash everything away.

Even with those moments, the river still felt like home. It was in those moments that I felt like I belonged, like our family was whole. It didn't matter what waited for us when we got home.

Out on the river, nothing else existed and for a little while, that was enough.

Chapter 7: The Day She Left

It was enough until she walked away. I didn't see it coming and I don't know if that made it better or worse. All I know is that one day she was there, and the next, she wasn't.

The sun was bright that day, bouncing off the river like diamonds scattered across the surface. I had spent the whole morning racing jet skis, wiping out, laughing with my sister, hearing my dad's voice boom from the boat as he cheered us on.

For some reason my mom didn't go with us on this trip. Without her, Dad was relaxed and focused his attention on me and my sister. The day was perfect.

When we packed up and left the river, something was off. I felt it before I saw it. When we arrived home from the river the house was too quiet. The air inside felt hollow, like something had been drained out of it. And then I realized why.

My mother's things were gone – her clothes, her jewelry, the little pieces of her that made our house feel like home.

All of it – gone. Just like that.

I stood in the doorway, staring at the empty space where she used to be. My dad didn't say much. Maybe he knew it was coming, maybe he didn't. All I knew was that she wasn't there and she wasn't coming back.

I told myself I didn't care; that she was weak for leaving and I didn't need her anyway. The truth was that her leaving wrecked me. Because if your own mother can walk away, what does that say about you?

Was I not enough? Did I do something wrong? Was there something about me that made it easier for her to go? I couldn't process it. I wouldn't process it. Instead, I did what I had already learned to do – I buried it.

I shoved the pain deep down where I thought it couldn't touch me and I kept moving.

Dad didn't leave, and in my young mind, that meant he was strong. He didn't cry about it or talk about it. He just moved on so that's what I tried to do as well. I started idolizing him in ways I never had before. He didn't let things break him. He didn't need anyone and that's the way I wanted to be.

But the truth was, he wasn't okay either. He spent more time in the garage – drinking, tinkering, distracting himself from whatever it was he didn't want to feel. I took that as a lesson. If you're hurting, you don't talk about it. You don't cry and you don't show weakness. You find something else to do; something to drown it out and take the place of whatever you lost.

When Mom left, my sister went with her. Michele was always the one who had it together. She did well in school and followed the rules. She made choices that took her forward. Me? I made choices that took me straight down.

I stayed with my dad and at 15, I thought I was making the right choice. Without my mom's presence and structure in the house, there was nothing holding me back anymore. She was the one who kept me from falling apart. There were no curfews and no rules. It felt like freedom, but real freedom doesn't destroy you. And I was about to find that out the hard way.

I started looking for something to replace that stability; something that made me feel like I still mattered. I was not ready to face the truth.

I felt abandoned, lost, and completely alone.

Chapter 8: The First Hit

I don't know if it was curiosity or if it was something deeper. It must have been something I was running toward without knowing it, and everything changed the day I found it.

It started in the most ordinary way. I was digging through Dad's toolbox, looking for something. What I found was a small bag of weed. I had smelled it before when my dad and his friends were out in the garage, talking and laughing. I never thought of it as something dangerous so I took a little. To me, I wasn't really stealing it. It felt more like an experiment.

I met up with my friends, Tim and Bobby, that day. We were just kids looking for something to do, something to pass the time. I pulled out the weed and asked them, "You ever tried this before?" None of us had, so we did what we had seen in movies – what we imagined we were supposed to do. We took a soda can, poked little holes in the top with a nail and packed the weed in.

One hit, then another – passing it back and forth, not even sure if we were doing it right. And then – I felt the euphoria. I remember feeling light, as if the weight I carried every day had just floated away. It was like nothing mattered anymore. For the first time ever, I wasn't thinking. I was just there and that was enough.

Once we were good and high, food sounded like the best idea in the world. We piled in the car and drove to the nearest Del Taco. Everything on the menu looked delicious so we placed our order. The lady told us our total came to just over \$300. We all laughed like idiots and decided to whittle the order down a bit. Those were the best tacos I ever ate.

Baseball had always been one of the places where I escaped to, but now, smoking weed became my favorite escape. It's not like I just woke up the next morning and decided to stop playing baseball, but something had shifted. Who needs coaches yelling at you and the constant demand to *play harder – run faster – do better?*

Weed didn't care if I struck out or was the fastest on the field, or if I was good enough for my dad. It made everything quiet and I liked the quiet. So I kept going back to it.

At sixteen, you don't think about addiction or where decisions lead. You don't stop to ask yourself – *What am I running from?* You just follow what feels good and for me, baseball had stopped feeling good.

But weed? Weed was like standing at the plate, waiting for the pitch, and not caring about striking out, and that felt good...for now.

Chapter 9: A Seed Takes Root

What started as an experiment quickly became a habit. At first, I only smoked when I was hanging out with my friends and we had nothing better to do. Soon, I was going back for more, sneaking into the garage when my dad wasn't around, and taking just enough to roll a joint or pack a pipe. It was too easy.

If my dad did it, why couldn't I? I told myself it wasn't a big deal and that it wasn't stealing. I was just taking a little and he would never miss it. Besides, it made me feel good.

Smoking became my escape from everything I didn't want to deal with – the confusion I felt but never spoke about and the nagging sense that something inside me was broken. I chased that feeling of calm, of weightlessness, of not caring. The more I did it, the more I realized something dangerous. Weed gave me confidence, or at least, it made me feel like I had confidence.

I was one of those kids who always questioned everything, with thoughts that ran too deep for my own good. I just couldn't accept things the way they were. When I smoked, all of that disappeared. It was an illusion, just like the smoke itself – there one second, gone the next.

I thought I had everything under control and had found the secret to making life easier. I didn't realize I was just following the same patterns my parents had fallen into – sweeping problems under the rug, numbing the pain instead

of facing it. I had seen my father drink to forget, smoke to escape, distract himself with his friends, his garage, and his toys, and I fell for it as well.

Soon, smoking wasn't enough. I started selling. Not because I needed the money, but because money meant power and freedom. It meant I could buy things for my friends and in my mind, that meant they would like me more. Having money made me feel more valuable. What I didn't know was that no amount of money or material possessions could fix what was broken inside me.

I started slipping at school. The straight-A student I had once been, who had loved learning and had excelled in every subject, was disappearing. I skipped class, fell behind, and just stopped caring.

The class clown routine, the jokes and sarcasm, and the need to entertain had become my identity. I used humor to mask the pain. More than anything, I just wanted to be seen. I perfected the art of hiding my true feelings and pretending I didn't care, when deep down, I cared a lot.

The mask I wore at school also hid my anger, which had become my armor. I was angry at my mom for leaving, at my dad for his distance, and at the world for being so unfair. Underneath all of that anger was a scared, lonely kid who just wanted to feel loved. I didn't know how to ask for that and didn't even know if I deserved it, so I buried it – and I kept smoking.

Weed was my escape hatch – my way to disappear without ever leaving the room. I told myself it helped me relax, cope, and forget, when really, it just helped me to *not feel*. But pain doesn't stay buried forever and eventually, the smoke wasn't enough.

Chapter 10: A Line in the Sand

The pain always resurfaced. No matter how hard I tried, I couldn't escape it. It had become part of my routine – sneaking into my father's toolbox, sliding it open just enough to grab what I needed. A little here, a little there; never enough for him to notice. Then one day, I found something else.

A small bag sat wedged between wrenches and screwdrivers, the contents shimmering slightly under the dim garage light. White crystals. I was intrigued. I had seen it before when I was in the D.A.R.E program as a kid. Curiosity was always my downfall.

Being inquisitive, if something was unknown to me, I had to figure it out. It was instinctive. I didn't see any danger; I saw an opportunity. I wasn't thinking – *This is bad. I should leave it alone.* No. My first thought was – *What is this? What will it do?* So I took a small amount because I just had to know.

I sat in my room, staring at the tiny white granules in my palm. My heart was beating a little faster than normal. Not with fear, but with curiosity, excitement, and anticipation.

I dipped my finger in, brought it to my nose and snorted it. The bitterness hit instantly – burned my nostrils and left a chemical taste dripping down my throat. My eyes watered and I coughed hard.

And then it hit. A surge of electricity – a rush of invincibility – a feeling I had never experienced before – power, control, sharpness, euphoria. It cut through the confusion I carried. It numbed the pain I didn't yet know how to name. For the first time in a long time, I felt like I could breathe.

By now, I had quit going to school altogether. Mom was gone, Dad was in his own world in the garage, and I had way too much freedom. Alcohol and weed were no longer enough to cover the pain. Now I had the white crystals and since Dad had a steady supply, so did I.

At first, it was manageable. I used it to disappear. I started smoking more, drinking more, using more. I surrounded myself with people who didn't care about the rules. Since I wasn't learning in school, I was learning on the streets – how to move, how to manipulate, how to numb. I learned that money meant power and power meant protection, and if I had something people wanted, I became valuable.

That's when Mark showed up.

Dad's new live-in girlfriend had a daughter named Leticia. Mark was one of her boyfriends and he stood out a bit among the rest. He saw something in me. Not because he cared, but because he saw what I had – meth.

Mark was older, street-smart, and he had connections. He knew people who would buy meth and pay good money for it. One day Mark said the words that shifted everything. "You could make real money with this." And just like that, I wasn't just using – I was selling.

The door swung wide open. We started cruising around together, hitting different neighborhoods, making drops, and pocketing cash.

I felt important, grown up, respected. I thought I was on top of the world. I was just a 15 year-old kid, but I had a seat in the game.

And the money! It felt good in my hands and made me feel untouchable, like I finally had something no one could take. Like I was building something for myself.

Cash – Status – Control – Power

Shoes – Clothes – Attention – Respect

For a kid like me, that was everything. I wasn't just a kid getting high; I was the kid with the product and the money. In my world, that meant I mattered.

I started believing that this was what rebuilding looked like. So what if my mom left, my home had crumbled, and my soul felt hollow. I was something! Or so I thought.

Growing up, getting gifts meant I was loved, so I bought things for people. I confused generosity with worth and for a while, it worked. People stayed close. I had my crew and what looked like acceptance. I was still just a kid, hiding under a mountain of bad choices and dollar bills. I told myself I was in control, that I was smart, that I was doing what I had to do.

I wasn't getting high – I was escaping.

I wasn't making money – I was buying validation.

I wasn't in control – I was spiraling.

But I was too blind and too stubborn to admit it. It ended the way so many things in my life ended – with betrayal. Mark never saw *me* – he saw a product, a hustle. I was useful until I wasn't.

Then one day, just like that – he was gone. Another lesson. Another reminder that people stick around only when you have something they want. He had used me and I had let him.

I wish I could say that was the wake-up call and that I recognized the path I was on and found a way out. But I didn't. I didn't want to. I had convinced myself this was where I belonged. This was survival. Power was protection and numbness was strength.

Looking back now, I see it so clearly. I was never in control. And that's how I crossed the line – not in any one moment, but in many small ones. Until one day, there was no turning back. I had stepped over the edge.

Chapter 11: Running from Reality

The day my father was arrested should have been another wake-up call. But at fifteen, I wasn't looking for clarity or change. I was looking for something – anything – that would numb the storm building inside me.

I walked into the house that afternoon like any other day, completely unaware that everything was about to change. The second I stepped inside, I knew something was wrong. The air felt heavy, charged with something I couldn't name.

And then I saw him – my father – sitting there in handcuffs. His head hung low, shoulders slumped forward. When he finally looked up at me, I saw something in his eyes I had never seen before.

He was crying.

I had always seen my father as indestructible. He was the punisher, the provider, the one who set the rules. But that day, he wasn't any of those things. He was just a broken man, shackled and waiting to be taken away.

I stood frozen, trying to process what I was seeing. The weight of it hit me all at once. This wasn't another argument, another bad night, another close call. This was the end of everything I knew. Without saying a word, I turned and ran.

I don't remember how far I ran or where I went. I just had to get away. The anger, the confusion, the helplessness – I didn't know what to do with any of it.

Nobody ever talked about emotions in my family, so I did what I had always done – I buried it. Pretended it didn't matter. And in burying it, I buried myself.

All I knew was that my dad – my supplier, my source, the lifeline to everything I had built around me – was gone.

With Dad gone, I ended up staying with his girlfriend, Judy, and her daughter, Leticia – the same Leticia I had tried so hard to impress, the one I thought could fill the void I didn't understand. But that didn't last long.

Some days later, we were at a house full of people I barely knew when the police came crashing through. It was like something out of a movie. Tear gas burned my eyes and lungs. Shouting, screaming, the thud of bodies hitting the floor. Officers stormed in, weapons drawn, barking orders over the chaos.

I was terrified. All I wanted was out. Somehow, I managed to call my mom. Not because I missed her or wanted to go home, but because I had nowhere else to go.

Things with Mom only got worse. I was angry and she was the only one left to take it out on. I stole from her. Lied to her. Manipulated her. I pushed her away even as part of me wished she would pull me back.

But she didn't – or maybe she just didn't know how. Either way, it didn't matter. In my mind, she was already gone.

I had lost my father to prison and my mother in a way I couldn't put into words. And then came the final blow – I lost my grandfather; the one steady presence I had left. Standing at his funeral, staring at him in that casket, death became real in a way I had never felt before.

I cried – deep, body-wracking sobs I couldn't control. It was the first time I'd really let myself feel, and I hated it. Hated how weak it made me seem. Hated that I couldn't fight it. Death was something I couldn't control, and I hated that most of all.

So I made a decision – I would never feel like that again. After the funeral, I shut it all down. I stopped feeling. Stopped caring. Stopped trying to make sense of anything.

What was the point? Everything good was temporary.

Everything I loved was taken from me. So I ran – harder this time – into drugs, into drinking, into the streets. The adrenaline, the thrill, the illusion of control – it all became my escape from a life that felt like it was crushing me.

By sixteen, life was a blur of chaos and bad choices. The streets felt like freedom, but they were a lie. They gave me a sense of power, but it was empty. They gave me an escape, but it was an illusion.

I told myself I was free, but I was trapped in anger, fear, shame, and in the weight of everything I refused to face. The harder I ran from reality, the more it closed in on me.

At night, when the high wore off and the streets grew quiet, the shadows crept in. The ache of not knowing who I was or where I belonged pressed down on me like a weight I couldn't shake.

I thought about my mom – how hard she was trying and how little I was giving back. I thought about my dad – locked away, and how his choices had become mine.

The more my mom fought to pull me back, the more I pushed her away. She saw her son slipping away and I saw her as interfering and controlling. Our arguments were loud, heated, and draining. I couldn't see that she loved me in the only way she knew how. All I saw was someone standing in the way of the life I thought I wanted.

But that life was a lie. The streets weren't freedom – they were a prison – a prison that was pushing me toward one with bars.

I couldn't see it then, but every decision, every outburst, every reckless move was sending me straight to rock bottom.

And I was racing toward it.

Chapter 12: Shattered Trust

Then, I met David. He was the neighbor of a friend of mine. He wasn't like the others in my life. He wasn't a street guy and he wasn't trying to hustle me. He was older, respected, successful, a paramedic.

Most importantly – he paid attention to me.

At first, it felt good to be noticed and valued. David became like a father figure to me – or so I thought. He made me feel safe and seen and like I mattered. He told me I was special, that I was worth something and had potential. And I believed him.

He took me places – concerts, amusement parks, restaurants I had never been to. He bought things for me – new clothes, nice shoes, video games. For a kid who had lost so much, those gifts meant everything. I felt chosen and important. I felt like maybe – just maybe – I had found someone who actually cared. For the first time in a long time, I thought things were turning around.

I wasn't skipping school as much. I wasn't stealing as much. I started thinking that maybe this was what I had been searching for all along.

But David wasn't saving me. He was grooming me and I couldn't see it. Not at first. The first time it happened, I froze. I didn't understand what was happening – and then I did but I didn't know what to do.

Something deep inside me screamed that this was wrong but I ignored that voice. *What if I was wrong? What if saying No meant losing him? What if this was just another thing I had to accept?* I had already been abandoned and betrayed so I told myself – *What's one more time?*

So I stayed quiet. I let it happen and convinced myself that I had no choice. The shame that followed was suffocating and I hated myself for it. But I didn't stop going back. David was still the only person in my life who made me feel like I mattered. At that point, it was worth everything.

Eventually, I told Mom about David. I don't know what I expected. Comfort, maybe; protection; for her to tell me it wasn't my fault; maybe just for someone to tell me that what was happening was actually real.

She didn't believe me. She asked me why, if it was true, wouldn't I tell my PO. I couldn't explain it. I was too ashamed and too humiliated to tell a complete stranger something so personal.

So instead of trying to make her understand, I just shut down. I looked her in the eyes and said, "Yeah, Mom, I'm lying."

And just like that – I was betrayed again. I resented her for years for that moment. I hated her for it. I was already drowning, losing myself, and when I finally reached out for help, she let me sink.

That was the moment that anger turned to rage and the numbness became permanent. That was the moment I stopped caring completely and started the robberies.

Chapter 13: Prey Becomes Predator

By this point, my life was not about survival anymore; it was about control. Every betrayal, every moment of powerlessness, every time someone took something from me, I carried that moment with me. Now – I was the one doing the taking.

The robberies weren't just about money and they weren't about feeding an addiction or keeping myself afloat. They were about making people feel what I had felt my whole life – powerless and scared. I had always trusted the wrong people and got used and thrown away. Now, when I walked into those homes – I held the knife and I made sure they felt it.

Manipulation was easy. I had learned how to talk my way into situations and how to make people trust me. Using their kindness against them was second nature by now. They wanted to believe they were doing something good. They wanted to believe in people like me – young, charming, harmless. And I used that against them.

But it still wasn't enough. The lies and words weren't enough. I wanted something more. I wanted to see real fear – the kind that shakes a person to their core and makes them freeze, unable to fight back. I wanted to hold power over someone the way others had held power over me.

The first time I walked into a house and pulled out my knife, it was like something inside me clicked into place.

It wasn't about the money, the valuables, or the things I could take. It was about knowing they were afraid of me. I saw it in their eyes.

It was the same fear I had felt when my parents were fighting and it felt like a war zone. The fear I had felt when my father was arrested and I realized I was alone. That same fear I felt when David took advantage of me and I had felt when my own mother didn't believe me. And now, I was the one causing it.

That feeling became addictive.

By the time I committed the fourth robbery, I wasn't thinking about people as people anymore; they were targets, stepping stones, nothing more than an opportunity.

I wasn't thinking about how they would feel after I left, how they would flinch at every noise, how their sense of safety would never return. They weren't real to me.

I had learned how to silence my conscience. I had spent years perfecting the ability to disconnect myself from emotions, from guilt, from anything that would slow me down.

That's how I justified ripping a purse out of an old woman's hands. She was no threat – fragile and defenseless. But that didn't matter. She had something I wanted and in my mind, that made it mine.

She had probably spent her whole life believing in the goodness of people. Believing that someone like me couldn't exist in her world and in one moment, I ripped that belief away from her.

I didn't think about how it might have changed her; how she might have cried when she got home; how she might have stayed awake that night, realizing that the world wasn't as kind as she once thought.

I didn't think about her at all. If I thought about her, I would have to think about myself and I wasn't ready for that – not yet.

I told myself I was just doing what I had to do; that the people I was taking from would be fine and that they had more than I ever would. I convinced myself that since life had betrayed me, I had every right to betray it right back.

But deep down, I knew the truth. None of this was filling the hole inside me. I could rob a thousand houses. I could put a thousand knives in people's faces. I could steal from a thousand defenseless old women and it would never make me feel whole.

But I still wasn't ready to face that truth, so I kept justifying my actions, and I kept running. I kept hoping the rage would go quiet, but it didn't. It just kept growing,

I couldn't see it then. I was lost and so full of anger and confusion that hurting others seemed like the only way to make sense of the world. I had been betrayed so many times that my heart had hardened and I could no longer recognize right from wrong.

My soul was screaming for help.

I was a prisoner to my rage, my past, and my pain, and I was about to cross a line that could never be uncrossed.

The worst part was – I didn't care.

Chapter 14: The Rage Inside

The rage inside me was no longer something I could contain. It had been building for years, layer by layer, betrayal after betrayal, pain stacked on top of pain.

The anger had become a living thing inside me; something that burned through my veins and dictated my every move.

At this point, there was no more reasoning, no more questioning, and no more reflection. I had given up the idea that my life could have gone any other way. I had told myself too many lies, buried my emotions too deep, and let my circumstances mold me into something I barely recognized.

I didn't just commit crimes – I became them.

I had convinced myself that the world owed me something; that my suffering gave me the right to inflict suffering on others. Every time I put a knife in someone's face, every time I made them tremble, every time I took what I wanted without asking, it was like I was reclaiming something that had been stolen from me and I kept pushing it further. I wasn't just some thief anymore or some kid trying to get by.

I didn't just want people to fear me – I needed them to.

There was no single moment that made me violent. I stopped seeing people as people. I was a predator and I didn't care. I had surrounded myself with others like me – users, manipulators, people who saw the world as something to take from rather than something to live in.

There were no real friendships, no real loyalty, and no real connections. Just temporary alliances built on what we could offer each other. Nobody in my life cared about me and I didn't care about them. We were all just playing a game and we all knew the rules.

Survival at all costs.

Take before you get taken from.

Hurt before you get hurt.

Win. Always win.

I had burned every bridge that had ever meant anything to me. My mother had given up hope and my old friends were long gone. The people I ran with would turn on me the second it benefited them. But that didn't matter to me because by then, I didn't even care about myself. It didn't matter and I didn't care.

When you reach a certain level of detachment and you no longer believe that anything in your life is real, you start making choices without hesitation. Nothing matters. There are no consequences; they were not even a consideration. There is only the next moment, the next move, and the next opportunity to take what you want. That's where I was and I had nothing left, so why stop now?

I carried David with me everywhere I went. His betrayal was fuel. When I robbed people, using my knife to instill fear in them, I thought of him. I wanted the world to feel as weak and powerless as he had made me feel. Every betrayal, disappointment, and abuse that had ever happened to me had become the rage within.

The cracks were widening.

Chapter 15: No Turning Back

The night I killed Jack, something inside me had reached its final point. The moment itself was a blur – rage, adrenaline, and a sense of being in control that I had never felt before. Once it was done and the reality settled in, I felt something I hadn't expected.

Nothing – no fear, no regret, no satisfaction; just emptiness.

For so many years, I had been consumed by anger, betrayal, and a desperate need to take back what had been stolen from me. Every robbery, every manipulation, every lie had been leading to this moment.

And now that I had done the ultimate thing, now that I had taken a life, I thought it would give me something. I thought it would make me feel powerful, unstoppable, untouchable.

Instead, it just made me feel more lost. There was no sense of victory and no rush; just silence.

I had told myself my whole life that if people could do whatever they wanted to me, why should I care about anyone else?

If my father could be taken away, if David could betray me, if my Mother could stop believing in me, then I had every right to take from the world whatever I wanted.

But standing there, staring at what I had done, I realized I wasn't in control at all, and never had been.

I tried to push it away. I repeated the same lies I had been telling myself for years.

He would have done the same thing to me if I hadn't done it first.

This is just how life works – kill or be killed.

This doesn't change anything.

It doesn't mean anything.

But this time I had taken something that could never be replaced. The home invasions, the thefts, the manipulation—they had all been temporary crimes. I had convinced myself that these were just things. Things people could recover from and move on from.

This was permanent. Jack was never going home again. His family would never see him again. He was never going to wake up and have a chance to do things differently – because of me.

I thought about his daughter, his mother, his friends – those people who would sit in shock when they got the call, who would wake up every morning and remember that someone they loved was gone forever.

I saw my own mother in them – the grief I had put her through. She had already lost my father and then had to watch as I threw my life away, becoming more and more like him. She had begged me to change and had held onto the hope I would.

But I had crushed it, over and over again.

The arrest came fast.

There was no getting out of it, no clever manipulation, no lie I could tell to undo what had happened. I was caught.

As they put the cuffs on me, I thought I would feel the same nothingness I had felt after the murder. That I would be numb, that I wouldn't care. I had done something that could never be undone. I had killed a man. I had to face the reality that I had become everything I hated. For the first time in my life, I couldn't run away.

All I felt was finality. Once again, I was powerless.

Chapter 16: Shattered Illusions

Now came the sirens. They cut through the night, echoing off the walls of the apartment complex; their wails sharp and unrelenting.

A few moments later I found myself standing in the living room of my home – frozen – my heart hammering in my chest as red and blue lights bounced off the windows. The flashing colors flickered across my mother's face, her expression shifting from confusion to something I couldn't quite place.

I tried to keep my face blank, to play it cool. But before I could even say a word, she turned to me, her eyes locking onto mine with a look that sent ice through my veins. "Did you have something to do with this?" she asked, her voice was steady but heavy, with something deeper.

I remember feeling like the ground beneath me had disappeared. How could she know? She had no way of knowing – not really. I had said nothing, done nothing to give myself away. And yet, she knew.

I tried to hold my composure. "No!" I said quickly, maybe too quickly. "Why do you ask?" I followed up, as if that would deflect suspicion.

She didn't answer right away. She just kept looking at me, searching my face for something – confirmation, denial, anything to tell her she was wrong.

I wanted to believe she was just scared, just reacting to the chaos outside, but deep down, I knew better.

She felt it. She had always had this way of knowing things, this intuition that seemed unfair, like some supernatural ability only mothers possessed. In that moment, she had looked straight into me, past whatever mask I was trying to wear, past the half-truths and the bravado, and she had seen me.

But before she could press further or I could say anything else, the pounding on the door shattered whatever moment was left. They were here.

The cops didn't waste time. They came in like a wave – fast and aggressive – their presence swallowing up the space around me. In the chaos, I barely registered what they were saying. Their voices blurred together as they closed in, asking questions, and issuing commands.

I didn't fight. I didn't resist. I just stood there as they pulled my arms behind my back, locking the cuffs tight around my wrists. The cold metal bit into my skin and for the first time, a sliver of reality began to seep through the numbness.

This was real. This wasn't a dream. As they led me outside, I saw my mother again. She hadn't moved from where she stood. She was watching. Her face was pale, her hands clutching each other as if holding on to something invisible.

Her eyes – those same eyes that had seen through me just moments ago – were filled with something I hadn't wanted to see.

Not anger. Not disappointed.

Pain.

I had seen her upset before. I had seen her frustrated, overwhelmed, exhausted. But this was different. This was something that was breaking inside of her.

I wanted to say something. I wanted to tell her I was sorry, that I never meant for any of this to happen, that I had never thought this far ahead. But what was the point? There were no words that could fix this.

So I didn't say anything. I just let them take me.

The police station was cold – colder than I expected. The walls were bare, the lighting harsh, and the air was thick with something that made my skin crawl. They put me in an interrogation room – just me and them.

No lawyer. No parent. Just me and two detectives who had done this a hundred times before.

“Just tell us what happened, Chris. We already know.”

I stared at the table, my hands cuffed in front of me, my wrists sore from the metal biting into my skin. I told myself I could beat them; that if I just kept my mouth shut, if I didn't give them anything, they wouldn't have enough to hold me.

But they were patient. They let the silence stretch between us, pressing down like a weight, suffocating in its own way. Then they started talking again.

“You don’t want to make this worse for your mom, do you?”

“You’re young. This doesn’t have to define you.”

“If you tell us the truth, we can help you.”

Lies. I knew they were lying.

I had seen enough movies and had heard enough stories. But I was sixteen, and no matter how much I had convinced myself I was grown, I wasn’t. They knew exactly how to break me. Then they brought up my dad.

“You can help your father, Chris. You don’t want to make this worse for him, do you?”

That was the final push. I caved. I told them everything. Every detail. Every moment. Every decision that had led me here. Thinking that maybe – just maybe – it would be enough to make this all go away; that if I gave them what they wanted, I’d wake up and find out this was all a bad dream.

But it wasn’t. As soon as the words left my mouth, the air in the room shifted. There was no relief. No moment of peace. Just the cold realization that I had sealed my fate.

Chapter 17: The Fight Within

Juvenile hall wasn't what I expected. The first thing I noticed was how quiet it was. Not silent, but eerily still. Controlled.

The door to my room didn't slam shut like in the movies. No echoing metal. No bars clanging. Just the soft click of a lock behind me – almost too soft for the weight it carried.

This was juvy, and it had its own rules. The doors were controlled by staff who called themselves *counselors* but they moved like security guards. They weren't the ones I worried about; it was the other kids who concerned me.

Once I was inside, it hit me – I wasn't special here. I wasn't the hardest or the most feared. I wasn't even seen and I wasn't a kid anymore – not in their eyes and not even in mine. The only thing that mattered now was how I handled myself.

At first, I kept it low-key. I didn't come in trying to prove something. I wasn't looking for a fight. I just wanted to survive. If I laid low, maybe I could ride it out.

But juvenile hall doesn't let you stay invisible. In here, you flock together or get picked apart. You moved with the people who looked like you, talked like you, acted like you. It wasn't about friendship – it was about survival. And survival meant adapting.

So, slowly, I started blending in.

Wine-making in the dorms. Sneaking food from the kitchen and talking back to the staff. Getting into scraps. Nothing big at first, just enough to send the message – I'm not weak.

Everything was intentional and I was building a reputation, little by little. When you're staring down a life sentence at sixteen, your reputation is the only currency you have.

Time passed differently in juvy. Some days dragged like years, others disappeared before I even realized it. But the tension never let up. It lived in the air, tight and constant, like something was always about to explode.

I didn't notice it at first. But as the months crawled by, I started feeling it – in my chest, in my jaw, in the way my fists clenched while I slept. There was a weight pressing down on me, heavier than the walls around me. It was the truth settling in.

I was here and I wasn't going home.
Not in six months. Not in a year. Maybe not ever.

I watched kids come and go. Some broke down and some got harder. I always wore my mask, but it was getting heavier. The anger was boiling. The shame, the fear, the silence – I couldn't show any of it. But I could feel all of it.

Then the moment came.

His name was Mr. Simms and he wasn't like the other staff. He was more direct. More hands-on. He didn't let much slide, and he didn't care who liked him. Worst of all, he saw through my act – and I hated that.

I don't even remember what started it – a comment, a challenge, a correction I didn't like. Something small, but small things ignite big fires when you're already full of gasoline. And that's what I was – months of pressure, pain, fear, and performance bottled up and looking for a spark.

I exploded.

One punch – blind, fueled by everything I couldn't say – caught him clean. Mr. Simms went down, and in that moment, it wasn't just a fight – it was a statement, a declaration.

I'm not soft, I'm not scared, and I'm not weak.

But that wasn't the truth. The truth was, I was terrified. Terrified of being forgotten, of being nobody. Terrified that if I didn't act out, I'd disappear into a system that would chew me up and never spit me back out.

That fight wasn't about Mr. Simms. It was about me; about a boy who had no idea how to survive without destroying something.

Chapter 18: The Gavel Falls

The first time I stepped into that courtroom, I felt nothing. It was just another room, just another part of this whole nightmare that didn't feel real.

But then I saw her.

My mother was sitting there, watching me with swollen eyes; her face lined with an exhaustion I had never seen before. She looked broken and I hated her for it.

I couldn't help but think – if she had loved me enough, if she had fought harder, if she had stopped my father from spiraling, if she had believed me about David, if she had done something different – I wouldn't be here.

At least, that's what I told myself. It was easier to blame her or anyone else rather than facing the truth and accepting that this was on me.

I sat there, stone-faced, watching her cry, feeling nothing but resentment. I hated that she still showed up and that she looked at me like I was that little boy she once tucked into bed at night. I wasn't that kid anymore. I was a monster now. And it was all because of them.

Days blurred into weeks and weeks into months. Court days were the worst. They became just another place I had to survive.

The routine never changed. We'd be up at the crack of dawn, long before the facility lights flipped on – wake up groggy, shuffle through the cold, wait in silence.

The holding cell was loud and it stunk. The air was thick with tension – part nerves, part sweat, part the kind of fear that no one dares admit out loud. We were just kids, but in there, we were treated like full-grown criminals.

We sat for hours, waiting to be processed, in a place where none of us wanted to be. Some cracked jokes. Some kept their heads down. Me? I kept my mask on – stone-faced, unmoved, unreadable.

At the end of each day came the shackles – rough cuffs snapped around our ankles with heavy chains wrapped around our waists, locking our wrists in place like we were animals. We were marched out by officers with short fuses and sharp tongues – men who didn't look at us like we were just kids.

We were loaded onto a bus, one by one, each of us sealed in a small, cold cage. And there we sat, locked down and silent. Talking wasn't allowed. If you broke the rules, you became the "example". It wasn't just physically uncomfortable, it was emotionally humiliating, but I got good at pretending it didn't bother me. My mask protected me.

My Mom was in the court room every day, and every time I looked up, her eyes found mine. She would try to smile and I would try not to look at her. My mask hid everything, but behind it, I was falling apart.

Then came the day my attorney pulled me aside and said the words that still echo in my mind. “Take the deal – thirty-six years to life. Otherwise, you’ll never go home.”

He made it sound simple. “You’ll only have to do eighteen before parole,” he said. “You won’t do the full time. You’ll be home one day.”

I was eighteen years old then. I was scared and desperate to believe him. So I nodded, signed, and told myself this was my way out. But it wasn’t a deal; it was a sentence; a slow death that I didn’t understand until it was too late.

In court, when the judge read my fate – *Thirty-six years to life* – I sat stone still. No tears. No questions. No begging. Just silence.

The gavel slammed and that was it. My future wasn’t mine anymore. I just sat there, silent, realizing what I had done.

I looked at Mom as they shackled me. She tried to stay strong, but I saw her heart breaking. The mask I wore told the world, *I got this*, but inside, I was collapsing.

My life wasn’t on pause – it was over. And the worst part was, I hadn’t even lived yet.

Chapter 19: Gladiator School

The guys in juvy talked about prison like a death sentence – *Lifers who never came home; men who died behind bars*. “Life, means life,” they said.

But before that came YA – Youth Authority, aka *Gladiator School*. That was what it was called in juvenile hall.

YA wasn't just another institution. It was a proving ground; a place where the weak were preyed upon and the strong climbed their way to whatever sliver of power they could grasp.

I had spent years pretending I wasn't afraid of anything, but in those last weeks in juvy, I had never been more afraid.

Here I was, waiting for the bus to hell. Headed to a world I didn't understand and could never be ready for – YA then prison. The words alone made my stomach turn.

The ride to YA was a nerve-wracking nightmare. We were all shackled and crammed together. The weight of what was ahead sat heavy in the air between us and none of us spoke much. Every moment felt like a countdown to something inevitable.

I had heard the horror stories about how whites had it the hardest. Survival meant proving yourself in ways I wasn't sure I could. I had no choice but to pretend. If I let even a sliver of my fear show, it could mean the end before I got started.

The moment we arrived, I felt the stares. Everyone was sizing me up, deciding where I fit into this world. The racial divide was clear; unspoken but undeniable. You stuck with your own or you were alone, and being alone wasn't an option.

YA meant walking a tightrope. Every word, every glance, every interaction had weight. It wasn't just about surviving physically. It was about making sure you weren't seen as weak. Weakness was a death sentence.

Then came the night that changed everything.

The institution was overcrowded and that meant cramming three people into cells designed for two. It wasn't just uncomfortable, it was dehumanizing. The air was thick with tension – bodies crammed together, nowhere to move, and nowhere to escape.

My cellmates – two other boys – spent most of their time talking among themselves. I kept to myself, headphones on, pretending to tune out the world.

But I could hear them.

Their conversation drifted through my ears and it sent a cold chill down my spine. They were talking about assaulting me. I kept my face neutral, my body still, and my breathing even, but inside, my heart was hammering.

My mind raced, trying to process what I had just heard. Were they serious? Was this a test? I couldn't afford to assume it was just talk. In here, everything had to be taken as a real threat.

My only choice was to act first.

Before they could make their move, I launched myself at one of them, fists flying. The other one jumped in and we fought, bodies slamming against the walls, fists cutting through the suffocating air of the tiny cell. I fought like my life depended on it, because it did.

Then, the guards came.

They yanked us apart; their voices barking orders I barely heard through the ringing in my ears. I was labeled the aggressor. I didn't care. I had made my point. Nobody was going to take advantage of me.

After that night, I was moved to a single cell and spent the rest of my short time in YA alone, staring at the walls, thinking about what came next. There was no peace in that cell, only the echo of what had happened and the looming reality of where I was heading next – prison.

This was just the beginning.

Chapter 20: The Long Ride to Nowhere

The ride from YA to the Tehachapi prison was the longest ride of my life. Physically, it was only a few hours but emotionally, it felt like an eternity.

I sat in that metal cage of a bus, shackled at the wrists and ankles, staring out through the steel mesh-covered windows, and watched the world I once knew fade into the distance.

I had left behind everything familiar – family, friends, even the twisted comfort of juvenile hall; a place I had come to know, for better or worse. Now, I was being sent into a world I had only heard about in war stories, and none of those stories ended well.

The weight of the chains felt heavier with each mile. The handcuffs bit into my wrists, the shackles cut into my ankles, but I barely noticed the physical discomfort. My mind was too busy racing; too caught up in the endless loop of questions that had no answers.

What was waiting for me on the other side? Would I survive this place? Was this really my life now? I wanted to believe this was just another stop, another temporary detour before I found my way back. But deep down, I knew the truth.

This was different. This was real.

The bus was packed with men of all ages and we all had one thing in common – we were headed to the same fate.

Some of the older guys looked unfazed – even relaxed, as if they were going home. Maybe they were. For them, prison wasn't an end, it was just another chapter in a life they had already accepted.

But for me – an eighteen year-old kid with a thirty-six year-to-life sentence – this wasn't just another stop. It was the rest of my life.

Nobody spoke much. The occasional whisper, the rustle of chains shifting, and the hum of the engine were the only sounds. My hands clenched into fists as I stared at my reflection in the window. I didn't recognize the person looking back at me. He had the same face, the same eyes, but there was something different now. Something hollow.

I had spent my time in juvenile hall convincing myself that I was ready for whatever came next. I had heard the stories, traded the rumors, and even imagined myself walking the yard, holding my own and earning my place.

But as the miles passed and Tehachapi grew closer, the bravado I had built up over the years started to crumble.

We stopped once, at some prison transfer facility, and the guards handed out brown-bag lunches – two slices of stale bread, a single slice of bologna, and a carton of warm milk. My stomach churned at the sight of it, but I forced myself to eat. Who knew when the next meal would come?

Another hour passed, maybe two. The landscape outside the bus window changed from the city streets I once roamed to the barren, sun-scorched landscape of the California desert.

And then, it came into view.

Like something out of a nightmare. Rows of tall fences, topped with razor wire. Watchtowers looming overhead. Guards armed and ready.

This was Tehachapi – my new home. As the bus slowed, my heart pounded so hard I thought it might burst through my chest. The reality of it all hit me like a sledgehammer.

There was no turning back. The life I had known was gone.

Chapter 21: First Steps into the Fire

The air inside the bus felt thick, like it was holding its breath right along with me. Faces were blank, but the tension was heavy. Every man was locked in his own head, just like I was. With a metallic hiss, the brakes settled and silence hung for half a second too long.

The bus doors slammed open. “Eyes forward! No talking! Keep it moving!” The officer’s voice was sharp, cutting through the air like a blade. I stepped off the bus, my shackles clanking with every movement, the sun blinding as it bounced off the concrete. The heat was suffocating and the dry air burned my lungs. We were lined up in the yard, a row of freshly processed bodies awaiting judgment.

And then, it began. The tough guy routine.

It was always the same – break the newcomers. Show them who was in control. Make sure they understood that whatever life they had before this moment no longer existed. An officer paced in front of us, barking orders, his voice thick with authority and arrogance. “You think you’re tough? You think you’re gonna run this place?”

Nobody answered. Then it happened. There’s always one.

Some guy snickered. Maybe it was nerves or maybe he thought he was still on the streets, untouchable. It didn’t matter. The officers pounced.

He was ripped from the line, slammed against the concrete, a knee pressed into his back as they shouted about respect, rules, and who really ran this place.

I stood completely still, watching from the corner of my eye, my stomach twisting. I had seen people get beaten before, but this was different. This wasn't a fight, it was a message. We own you now.

Suddenly, it clicked. Juvenile hall had been a cage, but this place was the jungle and I had just been thrown into the wild.

After the display of power, we were shuffled inside, one by one, into holding cells where we would sit for hours. Waiting. No one explained anything. We were stripped, searched, and given prison blues that hung off our bodies like we were wearing someone else's skin.

Then, medical evaluations, more waiting, and more silence. I watched men who had been through this before go through the motions like machines. No hesitation. No fear. Just acceptance. I wanted to believe I could be like them, but I was terrified.

My name was finally called and I was given my housing assignment. I had heard enough about Tehachapi to know that where you were housed mattered. Some places were better than others; some were war zones.

They didn't tell me where I was going. They just handed me a thin mattress, a few hygiene products, and told me to follow the line.

As I walked through the corridors, my heart pounded in my chest. When I stepped into my cell and the door slammed

shut behind me for the first time, the sound echoed off the walls like a death sentence.

I looked around. Small. Cold. The air was thick with sweat, fear, and time. My cellmate barely glanced at me before turning back to whatever he was doing. There were no introductions. No words. Just silence.

I sat on the bunk, staring at the wall with my mind racing. I had spent years convincing myself that I was ready for this moment. But as I sat there, listening to the sounds of the prison come to life around me, I realized I had been lying to myself.

This wasn't like juvenile hall. This wasn't just another place to survive. This was the rest of my life and I had no idea how to make it out alive.

Chapter 22: Entrenched in The Abyss

The days turned into weeks, the weeks to months, the months to years, and before I knew it, prison wasn't just where I was – it was who I was. The walls that confined me didn't just keep me in, they stripped away everything I once was and replaced it with something darker and hardened.

I didn't just survive prison – I became it.

There were no second chances here and no space for weakness. Respect was everything and the white race had rules. If you had a problem, you handled it. There were no warnings, no second conversations – just steel. You either earned your place or you got out of the way.

I found my lane early on – prison wine. Everyone had their hustle and this was mine. The prison economy ran on vices and I knew how to meet a demand. I learned the process, the ingredients, and the secrecy of making something out of nothing.

Selling wine wasn't just about the money – it was about having something to offer for trade. It gave me a position. I wasn't running the yard, but I wasn't at the bottom either. I had something people wanted and in prison, that was its own power.

But power didn't mean protection. If you had a problem, you handled it yourself. That was the code.

If you let something slide, it meant you were weak. In here, weakness got you erased.

Time moves differently in prison. Days stretched, but the years disappeared. My first decade inside was a blur of routine, manipulation, and addiction. I played the game and I didn't go looking for fights. I knew when to keep my head down and when to stand firm.

The drugs kept me numb – heroin when I needed to check out and meth when I needed to stay sharp. It was a cycle of getting high to forget, coming down, and then starting all over again. If I wasn't high, I had to feel. Feeling meant facing what I had done and what I had lost. That wasn't an option.

I wasn't a kid anymore and I wasn't just an inmate. I had *become* the lifestyle. I wasn't just making prison wine, I also began to sell weed. It started small – a few grams here and there – just enough to flip and keep my own habit going.

But when you have a hustle in prison, word spreads. Soon, I had access to something bigger – a pound of weed.

I had connected with the right people, learned the right moves, figured out how to work the system, and for a while, it was easy money. Until I got caught.

I was hit with a new charge and sent to the SHU – the Security Housing Unit. Solitary. Locked away twenty-three hours a day with one hour of yard time in a cage. No contact. No movement. No escape.

The SHU broke people. But I thought I was already broken, so what difference did it make?

After years of playing the game came the test.

I had always managed to steer clear of being called on to “handle business”, but then came Chris – a man in our group who had been labeled a snitch.

In prison, that meant one thing – he had to go.

My cellie was called on to do it, but he had a parole date and I had life, so I raised my hand. I didn’t want to, but I wanted to be seen as someone who would step up, who would help a friend, someone who would put in work. It was my turn to prove myself.

A razor blade was placed in my hand and my heartbeat pounded in my ears as I approached Chris. I had laughed with him before and shared a meal, but none of that mattered now. The rules had been set.

I was expected to do what countless others before me had done – enforce the politics.

I wish I could say I refused, that I stood up and said, "This isn't me." But that's not what happened. I did what was expected. I sliced Chris's throat and ran away and tried to flush the weapon. My friend, Chip, started a fight to create a distraction.

I had let fear dictate my actions. Afterward, as I washed the blood from my hands, I told myself it was necessary and that I had no choice. But in the quiet of my cell that night, I knew the truth.

I had a choice and I had chosen wrong.

This cycle repeated itself over and over.

Manipulation – Violence – Survival.

Every day was another test of loyalty, another moment where I had to prove that I was someone I wasn't. The more I played the role, the more I became it. The mask I wore was no longer just for protection; it had become my reality.

I thought about the innocence I had lost long before stepping into this place; about the life I had left behind and about the family who had once tried to love me. I had been baptized by fire, shaped into someone I barely recognized, and for a long time, I believed there was no way out. This was who I had to be. It was what I was meant to be and all I would ever be.

As the months melded into years, the relentless cycle of prison life continued to forge my existence in ways that I eventually came to accept. The fire that I believed purified, also calcified, layering me with a new armor that was as imprisoning as it was protective.

The reality of my daily existence demanded compliance and offered harsh lessons on the cost of holding onto past identities.

Each day, each fight, each compromise of my old values moved me further from the man I had once hoped to be, toward the specter of the man that prison was shaping me into.

Chapter 23: Becoming the Monster

One night, the weight of my addiction and anger collided in a way that exposed the depths of my brokenness. I had been drinking heavily and I could barely think clearly.

As a porter in the building, I had responsibilities, but that night, I couldn't be bothered to follow the rules. I was consumed by the distorted belief that my defiance gave me power and my hostility made me irrational.

When Officer Tremble told me to lock up, something in me snapped. I flew off the handle, grabbed a bucket and hurled it against the wall. The sound of it crashing reverberated through the building, but I didn't stop there. I became hostile, cussing at Tremble and acting like I was untouchable.

It was all bravado – a mask of toughness I thought could shield me from the world. In reality, it was a pathetic display of my own inner turmoil.

“Cuff up!” Tremble demanded, his tone firm but steady.

“No!” I spat back in defiance. I thought refusing him made me powerful and that standing my ground would earn me respect. But in truth, I was just digging myself deeper into a pit of self-destruction.

Tremble stood there, calmly waiting for my tirade to end. When it finally did, he looked at me with a mixture of pity

and resolve and said something I wasn't prepared for. "You're better than this. You don't have to live like this forever."

The words hit me like a blow, but not because of their simplicity. It was because they came from someone who had no reason to say them. Tremble didn't know me – not really. He didn't know my past, my pain, or the choices that had brought me here. But for a moment, I believe he saw something in me that I couldn't see. And that scared me.

Eventually, my false sense of control crumbled and I gave in. The officers escorted me back to my cell, where my drunken tirade continued. I yelled, cussed, and slammed my fists against the walls, letting out every ounce of anger and frustration I had bottled up inside.

As the hours dragged on, exhaustion overtook me and I finally collapsed into an uneasy sleep.

The next morning, I stumbled out of my cell, hungover and drained. I went to pick something up at the podium in the day room and I saw Officer Tremble standing there. As I approached, he motioned for me to step aside. His expression wasn't angry; it was something else entirely, something I never expected.

"Kelly," he said, his voice calm but firm, "are you going to keep acting like the same fool I saw fifteen years ago, or are you finally ready to grow up?"

I froze. His words hit me like a punch to the gut.

Tremble wasn't just a guard enforcing the rules, he was a man speaking directly to my soul. He had seen me at my worst, and yet here he was, calling me out, not to humiliate me but to challenge me.

In that moment, I could no longer hide from the truth.

I had spent years blaming others, hiding behind excuses, and pretending that my destructive behavior was just a product of my environment. Tremble's words forced me to confront a harsh reality.

The person I had become was a result of my own choices.

The rest of the day, his words replayed in my mind, cutting through the haze of my usual justifications. For years, I had convinced myself that I was untouchable, that my actions didn't matter, and that no one cared about what I did or didn't do.

But here was a man who, with a few simple words, showed me otherwise.

That moment didn't change me instantly. I was still wrestling with the weight of my addiction and the habits that had defined me for so long. But something had shifted. For the first time in years, I allowed myself to look in the mirror and truly see the person staring back at me.

It wasn't a pretty picture, but it was the first step toward something better. The truth hurt, but it was a catalyst, igniting a flicker of hope that perhaps – just maybe – I could become more than the sum of my mistakes.

Chapter 24: Balancing on the Edge

Prison didn't just confine me; it consumed me. I didn't wake up one day and decide to become a hollow version of myself. It happened slowly, quietly, and then all at once.

At first, I was just trying to survive. Keeping my head down when I had to and standing tall when the moment demanded it. But behind the jokes, the hustle, and the hard shell was a man unraveling.

I had become a garbage disposal for anything that could help me forget – heroin to check out, meth to stay sharp, weed, alcohol, pills, pruno – whatever numbed the ache of knowing I'd built a reality I couldn't stand.

If I wasn't high, I had to feel. And I wasn't ready to feel.

So I got good at pretending. Everywhere I went, the story was the same: *I'm fine. I'm handling it.* But behind closed doors, I was drowning in silence and shame.

The drugs kept me numb, the politics kept me loyal to a life I didn't want anymore, the violence kept me from thinking too deeply, and the mask kept me from admitting I was breaking.

Prison doesn't reward honesty. It rewards performance. So I performed. I had a hustle and enough status to matter. But the truth was I was dying inside.

The deeper I sank into addiction, the more damage I did, not just to myself, but to everyone around me.

After the night I had chosen to slice a man's throat to prove I belonged, I kept telling myself that it was necessary, that I had no choice if I wanted to survive.

But I knew better. I always had a choice, and I had chosen wrong...over and over again.

When fear runs your life, you stop asking what's right. You only ask – *What will keep me safe today?*

In all that darkness, something else began to stir.

Not shame – I was already drowning in that. But a quiet voice began to speak. One I had buried for years.
You were made for more than this...

Conviction.

It whispered during the rare moments I wasn't high. It showed up in the mirror, when the hollowness got too loud to ignore. It crept in through the pages of a Bible I didn't yet know how to read. It pulsed in my gut every time I said *I'm fine* and knew I wasn't. That voice was steady and it wasn't mine.

I see it now. It was God.

Even while I was drowning in addiction and destruction, *He* was already calling me Home. But I wasn't ready to answer. So I stayed in the middle; in the game but on the fence. Numb. Lost. Pretending. And no matter how much I smoked, injected, drank, or swallowed, the pain was still there.

That mask – the one I had worn since I was a kid – it was starting to crack.

The truth was this –

I wasn't getting high...I was escaping.

I wasn't making money...I was buying validation.

I wasn't in control...I was unraveling.

Every lie I told myself bought me another day of pretending.

But I could feel the end coming. Not the end of my life, but the end of who I had become and that was terrifying.

If I wasn't that guy anymore...Who was I?

That question haunted me. What I didn't realize then was this –

The crack in the mask was the beginning of my healing.

Chapter 25: Messengers of Grace

Amid the iron bars and the harsh realities of Calipatria State Prison – yet another prison among the 6 that I had spent time in – divine intervention came. Not with a thunderous voice from the heavens, but through the quiet companionship of two fellow inmates – a fellow named Chris and another named Michael. Each, in his own right, was a testament to the power of enduring faith and the transformative grace of God.

In the undercurrents of prison life, where despair often drowns hope, Chris stood as a beacon of perseverance and truth.

It was in the prison kitchen – a place echoing with the clang of metal and hushed conversations – that I found brief escapes in the solace of heroin. Each return from these fleeting escapes was met with Chris's discerning gaze, his eyes reflecting not judgment, but an understanding forged in the fires of his own battles with addiction.

Chris's approach to mentorship was characterized by a rare authenticity. He knew when to speak truth and when to offer silent solidarity. His past struggles lent him an empathetic perspective that was both relatable and inspiring.

Over shared meals and amidst the mundane tasks of kitchen duties, Chris shared his story of redemption; a narrative that slowly chipped away at the walls I had built around my own vulnerabilities.

His patience was a constant reminder that transformation does not occur in isolation or haste, but through continuous and mindful efforts. Chris' presence in my life challenged me to redefine what I perceived as strength – not as the ability to endure suffering alone, but as the courage to confront and change one's course.

The day Michael re-entered my life, he brought with him a melody of change that resonated deeply within the concrete confines of the yard. His transformation was profound, a stark departure from the man I had met over 20 years ago. There he stood, a guitar in his hands, his voice weaving gospel hymns into the stale air – a daring display of his newfound faith.

I approached him with a mixture of skepticism and curiosity, to which he responded with a warmth that belied the coldness of our surroundings. Michael spoke of a heart and mind renewed by divine grace. His words were imbued with a conviction that captivated my attention. This encounter, marked by his unexpected vulnerability and the depth of his spiritual conviction, planted seeds of contemplation within me.

Why? Because his transformation posed a powerful counterpoint to the life I had known, which was marked by struggle and strife. It forced me to reconsider the possibilities of my own life's trajectory, challenging me to envision a future where faith could guide my decisions rather than the hardened codes of prison survival.

Together, Chris and Michael embodied the dual aspects of God's grace in action – Chris through his steadfast presence and Michael through his serene testament to faith's renewing power.

Their combined influence gradually eroded my skepticism, replacing it with a budding belief in the possibility of personal rebirth.

Their guidance – offered through shared experiences and rooted in genuine concern – provided a firm foundation upon which I could start to rebuild my life. They demonstrated that redemption was not merely about turning away from one's past, but actively moving toward a future shaped by higher spiritual commitments.

As I navigated the complex tapestry of prison politics and personal demons, Chris and Michael's examples served as beacons, illuminating a path defined by integrity and purpose. They taught me that true freedom was not about escaping physical confines, but about liberating oneself from the internal chains of past mistakes and misdeeds.

Their influence extended beyond the immediate challenges of prison life, helping me to cultivate resilience and a renewed sense of self.

They were not just mentors but living proof that change was attainable, urging me to embrace a journey of continuous transformation – a journey marked not by the absence of struggle, but by the presence of enduring hope.

Chapter 26: Whispers of Grace

A turning point came with my mother. She had always been my anchor; the glue that held the family together before life tore us apart. Even after years of chaos and separation, she never gave up on me.

When I found out she had been diagnosed with lung cancer, it felt like the world shifted beneath my feet. I called her, desperate to know how I could help. Her answer was so simple, yet so profound. “I just want to see you get out of prison. But for that to happen, you need to change.”

By 2016, I was tired – not just of prison – but of the life I had been living. Addiction, anger, and self-destruction had ruled me for so long that I couldn’t imagine a different way of being, but that year, everything started to change.

It wasn’t fast or easy, but it was real. It started with one simple decision – let God take control.

My mom’s words cut through the haze I had been living in. I knew she was right. I had spent decades in the grip of heroin addiction, making the same choices over and over again, and expecting a different outcome. But change felt impossible.

Drugs had been my crutch for so long that I didn’t know who I was without them. I had defined myself by the worst parts of my story – the drugs, the crimes, the politics of prison. Now, I had to figure out who I was without all of that.

The idea of letting go was terrifying, but something about my mother's plea stayed with me and I leaned on a motto that carried me through the hardest moments – *Embrace the discomfort*.

I prayed.

At first, it felt awkward – like speaking to someone I wasn't sure was listening. But I was desperate. I asked God to help me stop using, to give me the strength I didn't have on my own, and to please help my mom.

I expected the worst. After eighteen years of addiction, I knew what withdrawal looked like – pain, sickness, and desperation. But that's not what happened.

To my amazement, *there were no withdrawal symptoms!* Not a single one. I waited for the agony to come, but it never did. I didn't feel the ache in my bones or the feverish desperation I had seen destroy so many others.

I was free, and there was no doubt in my mind where that freedom came from. It wasn't my strength that carried me through – it was God's.

I clung to that realization in the days that followed, reminding myself that what had happened wasn't just chance. It was grace. And yet, quitting drugs was only the beginning. Breaking the chains of addiction wasn't just about getting clean; it was about transforming my entire life.

I realized that completely overhauling my life meant stepping out of every comfort zone I had ever known. It meant facing the guilt and shame I had buried for so long.

Most of all, it meant trusting God to guide me through the unknown.

The journey wasn't easy. Stepping away from the politics of prison put me in a vulnerable position and I knew that every move I made was being watched.

But for the first time, I wasn't acting out of fear. I wasn't trying to prove anything to anyone. *I was simply trying to live in a way that honored the grace I had been given.*

Embrace the discomfort. That phrase became my lifeline and it reminded me that growth wasn't supposed to be easy or painless. It was supposed to challenge me, to stretch me, to make me stronger. With every step I took, I felt the chains that had bound me for so long begin to fall away.

Breaking the chains wasn't a single moment or a single choice. It was a process – a long, painful, beautiful journey of transformation. In September 2016 – for the first time in my life – I felt free. Not just free from addiction, but free from the lies I had told myself for so many years. I was free to believe that I was worth saving.

That was the year everything changed. It wasn't the end of my struggles, but it was the beginning of something new – a life of purpose, faith, and hope.

For the first time in my life, I believed that freedom was possible. But prison has a way of testing belief. It doesn't just let you change without a fight.

Chapter 27: The Struggle Within

Even as I began to hear the whisper of grace and take steps toward change, the struggle within me was relentless. Transformation wasn't a straight path; it was messy, painful, and full of setbacks.

For every moment of hope, there were countless moments of doubt, guilt, and shame. My faith was growing, but so were the temptations to fall back into old patterns. It felt like a war was being waged inside me – a battle between the man I wanted to become and the man I had been for so long.

Prison was a constant reminder of my past.

The environment demanded toughness, loyalty to the politics, and an unflinching adherence to unspoken rules. Every day felt like a test of my resolve.

Walking away from the politics wasn't as simple as just deciding not to participate. It meant distancing myself from people I had once called family; people I had fought alongside and for. The prison yard is a battlefield and when you step off the field, you are a target.

The internal pull to return to what I knew best was strong. There were moments when I questioned whether the fight was worth it. *Was it easier to just go back to the comfort of my old life? To fall in line with the politics, the drugs, the violence?*

Those things had defined me for so long that stepping away felt like stepping into a void. Who was I without them?

The guilt and shame were constant companions. No matter how much I prayed or how many steps I took in the right direction, the weight of my past followed me.

I thought about the people I had hurt, the victims of my crimes, their families, and my own family. I thought about my mother, who was battling cancer and holding on to hope that I would get out of prison one day. The burden of knowing how much pain I had caused often felt suffocating.

And yet, in those moments of despair, I clung to the faint glimmers of hope I had begun to experience.

God's grace didn't erase my past, but it gave me the strength to confront it. The more I leaned into my faith, the more I began to understand that guilt and shame didn't have to define me. They were part of my story, but they weren't the end of it.

The struggle within wasn't just about resisting external temptations; it was about learning to see myself differently.

For years, I had identified as an addict, a criminal, and a failure. Those labels had become my reality, shaping how I saw myself and how I believed others saw me. Letting go of them meant redefining my identity, not as the sum of my mistakes – but as a child of God – forgiven and loved despite everything.

But change isn't linear. There were days when the pull of the past felt stronger than the promise of the future, days when the anger and bitterness I had carried for so long bubbled back to the surface. I would lash out, slip into old habits of thinking and feel the weight of failure all over again.

It was in those moments that the struggle was most intense and the battle for my soul was most visible.

Through it all, I leaned on the tools I was learning to trust – prayer, scripture, and the small but growing community of people who supported me.

Chris continued to challenge me, his honesty kept me grounded when my thoughts threatened to spiral. Michael's example of unwavering faith showed me what it looked like to trust God, even when the path ahead was unclear.

The Bible became a source of comfort and conviction. I would spend hours reading and reflecting, finding truths that seemed written for me. Verses about forgiveness, redemption, and renewal began to re-shape how I saw my story.

I realized that God wasn't asking me to erase my past. He was asking me to use it, to let it be a testimony of His power to redeem even the most broken lives.

The struggle within didn't end overnight, but for the first time in my life, I felt like I had a fighting chance.

In many ways, it still hasn't ended, but those early days of wrestling with my past, my choices, and my identity were the foundation for everything that followed. Each step forward, no matter how small, was a victory in a battle I had thought was lost.

In the darkest moments of the struggle, I learned to hold on to one unshakable truth – God's Grace was enough; it was enough to cover my sins, enough to guide me through the temptations, and enough to remind me that I was not fighting this battle alone.

Slowly but surely, I began to believe that the man I had been does not define the man I could become.

Chapter 28: Light Exposes the Darkness

Change wasn't a neat process; it was uncomfortable, messy, and often painful. The deeper I leaned into my faith, the more I realized that transformation wasn't just about breaking habits or making better choices. It was about allowing God's Light to shine into the darkest corners of my soul, exposing the parts of me I had tried to hide for so long.

When that Light revealed the truth, it wasn't easy to face.

My whole life had been built on lies – lies I had told myself about who I was, what I deserved, and why I had done the things I'd done. I had told myself that the violence, the drugs, and the manipulation were just part of survival, that I was a victim of my circumstances, a product of my environment, and nothing more.

But as God's Word began to take root in my heart, those lies started to unravel.

The Bible wasn't just a book of comfort, it was a mirror, reflecting back the truth about who I was and who I could become. Passages like, John 8:32 – *"Then you will know the truth, and the truth will set you free."* – cut through my defenses.

The truth wasn't just about what I had done, it was about the motives and fears that had driven me. It was about the pride and anger that had kept me locked in chains long after the prison gate had closed behind me.

At first, it was overwhelming. The Light exposed not only the darkness of my past but the darkness that still lived within me. There were moments when the weight of it all felt crushing. I saw the pain I had caused, the lives I had hurt, the trust I had broken, and the people I had betrayed.

It was tempting to retreat back into the shadows, to pretend that those truths didn't exist. But God's Grace wouldn't let me.

Through prayer and reflection, I began to understand that the purpose of the Light wasn't to shame me; it was to free me. The more I allowed God to shine His Light into my life, the more I began to see the cracks in my armor for what they were – opportunities for Him to step in and heal what I couldn't fix on my own.

One of the hardest truths to face was the realization that I had been living in fear for most of my life. Fear of being abandoned, fear of being seen as weak, fear of never being enough. That fear had driven me to make choices that weren't just destructive, they were sinful.

I had hurt people in my attempt to protect myself, and I had clung to power and control because I was terrified of being vulnerable.

But the Light showed me that true strength didn't come from pretending to be invincible. It came from surrendering to God and letting Him work through my weaknesses.

It wasn't just my past actions that God's Light exposed; it was my present struggles, too. Even as I prayed and read the Bible, I found myself wrestling with old temptations. The pull of the politics, the lure of the shortcuts that had once defined my life, didn't disappear overnight.

There were days when I slipped, when my anger got the best of me, or when I found myself slipping into the mask I had worn for so long. But each time, the Light reminded me that I didn't have to stay in the darkness.

One of the most profound lessons I learned was that God's Light didn't just expose the darkness – it transformed it.

The very things I had been most ashamed of, the things I thought disqualified me from grace, became the building blocks of my testimony. They weren't erased. They were redeemed. God was taking the broken pieces of my life and using them to create something new.

The light also revealed something I hadn't felt in years – *Hope*. Hope that my story wasn't over and that the person I had been didn't have to define the person I could become. It was a hope rooted, not in my own strength, but in God's ability to do what I couldn't. Slowly, that hope began to replace the fear that had ruled me for so long.

Letting God's Light into the darkest parts of my life was one of the hardest things I've ever done, but it was also one of the most liberating. It forced me to confront the truth and it gave me the freedom to move forward.

For the first time, I could see the path ahead – not clearly and not without obstacles, but with the assurance that I wasn't walking it alone. The light wasn't just exposing the darkness; it was leading me out of it.

The darkness was losing its power to control me.

Chapter 29: Regeneration

As the Light of God exposed the darkness within me, I began to change. Slowly and painstakingly, I was learning to live a new kind of life.

For so long, I had defined myself by my worst moments. The crimes, the addiction, and the violence were the sum total of who I believed I was. Allowing God's Truth to reshape my heart and mind, I began to see myself differently. I wasn't just a man in chains, I was being remade and stepping into a new identity.

I began to understand that being transformed wasn't about erasing the past, but about redeeming it. God wasn't asking me to forget the pain or the choices that had brought me to this point. He was asking me to trust Him to use those experiences for something greater.

I clung to God's Word as my guide. Verses like, 2 Corinthians 5:17, *"If anyone is in Christ, he is a new creation. The old has passed away; behold, the new has come."* These words became my mantra. Every time I doubted my ability to change, every time the pull of the past felt too strong, I reminded myself that I wasn't doing this alone. God was working in me and His strength was greater than my weakness. As I let go of old patterns, I began to replace them with new ones.

I threw myself into studying the Bible, devouring its truths and letting them shape my perspective.

I started taking steps toward a better future by pursuing education – earning degrees in Social and Behavioral Sciences, and in Business Administration.

These were more than just achievements – they were acts of defiance against the version of myself I had been for so long. The more I embraced this new life, the more I felt the chains of my past fall away.

I was leaving the old me behind and discovering who I could become.

I started to see myself as someone with purpose; someone who could make a difference even within the walls of prison. I began mentoring younger men, sharing my story, and encouraging them to believe that change was possible.

For the first time, I felt like my pain and mistakes weren't wasted – they were tools God could use to help others.

The most profound change wasn't just in my actions, it was in my heart. The anger and bitterness that had consumed me began to give way to forgiveness and grace.

I started to see the men around me differently – not as enemies or threats but as broken people in need of the same redemption I had found. That shift wasn't easy. It required humility, empathy, and a willingness to let go of pride, but it was worth it.

The journey of regeneration was far from over, but I could see the evidence of God's work in my life. I was becoming someone I never imagined I could be – someone *free*, not just from addiction or prison politics, but from the lies and shame that had held me captive for so long.

I wasn't perfect and I still stumbled, but I no longer defined myself by my past. I defined myself by the Grace that was rebuilding me from the inside out.

Regeneration wasn't just about me; it was about the people I could now serve, the hope I could now share, and the purpose I could now live out.

God was turning my brokenness into something beautiful and for the first time, I could see a future worth fighting for.

Chapter 30: The Cost of Change

Transformation always comes at a cost and for me, it was steep. As I began to shed my old identity and embrace the person God was calling me to be, I realized that change wasn't just about letting go of bad habits – it was about losing parts of my life that had once felt essential.

The things I had built my world around – loyalty to the politics of prison, the false sense of security in my old ways, and the relationships I thought defined me – were now barriers to the new life I was trying to create. Walking away from them wasn't just painful, it was terrifying.

The prison yard has its own code, its own structure, and leaving that structure meant stepping into the unknown. The men I had once called brothers – the ones I had fought for and with – now looked at me differently.

My decision to walk away from the politics and violence was seen as weakness and even betrayal. In their eyes, I was turning my back on everything I had claimed to stand for. The whispers started, the sideways glances, the subtle signs that I was no longer one of them.

At first, I tried to justify it to myself. Maybe I can change without walking away completely. Maybe I can live in both worlds. But deep down, I knew the truth – to fully embrace the life God had for me, I had to let go of the life I had built in prison. There was no middle ground.

The cost of change was total and I had to decide if I was willing to pay the price. One of the hardest losses was the friendships I had formed over the years. These weren't surface-level connections; these were bonds forged in the fire of survival.

But as I stepped into a new way of living, I began to see that many of those relationships were built on a foundation that couldn't last.

Loyalty in prison was often transactional, rooted in what you could do for someone, not in who you were. Walking away meant losing people I had once considered family, but it also meant gaining something far greater – Peace.

As the relationships faded, I began to build new ones. Men like Chris and Michael stood by me, offering support and encouragement when I needed it most. Their friendship wasn't based on manipulation or politics; it was rooted in faith and honesty. They reminded me that true loyalty didn't come from fear or obligation, but from a shared commitment to growth and purpose.

My mother, who was fighting cancer and holding on to hope for my release, became a constant reminder of the impact my choices had on others. Her love and belief in me gave me strength, but it also forced me to face the weight of my failures.

Letting go also meant losing the comfort of my old identity. For so long, I had defined myself by the labels others had given me – addict, criminal, convict. Even as I rejected those labels, I found myself wondering who I was without them.

The process of discovering my new identity was liberating and disorienting. I had to learn how to live as someone who

wasn't controlled by anger, fear, or addiction. It was a daily battle, but it was one I was finally willing to fight.

Despite the pain and uncertainty, the cost of change was worth it. Each step away from my old life brought me closer to the freedom I had longed for; not just physical freedom, but the freedom to live with integrity, purpose, and hope. I began to see that every loss was making room for something better.

The relationships I let go of were replaced with ones built on trust and faith. The identity I surrendered was replaced with one rooted in God's Grace.

There were moments when the pull of the past felt almost unbearable. I would catch myself slipping into old thought patterns or feeling the sting of rejection from those I was moving away from. And each time, I would remind myself why I had chosen this path.

The cost of change was high, but the cost of staying the same was even higher.

The most valuable lesson I learned during this time was that transformation isn't just about what you gain – it's about what you're willing to lose.

The life I had built in prison was a prison of its own. Leaving it behind was necessary, and with every step, I found myself drawing closer to the man I was meant to be.

Chapter 31: Divine Appointments

By 2018, as I was walking deeper into my faith, I met someone who would become one of the most influential figures in my spiritual journey – Morgan “Smitty” Smith. God placed him in my life at exactly the right time, just as He had done with Chris and Michael before him. Each of these men had been instrumental in my transformation and Smitty was no exception.

We met in the chapel at Ironwood, where Smitty worked as the porter. When I was assigned a job there as a clerk, our paths naturally crossed and we connected instantly. There was something magnetic about Smitty – his calm presence, his deep knowledge of God’s Word, and the way he carried himself with humility and purpose. It was clear that God was using him to guide me, to teach me, and to refine me.

Our friendship grew quickly, rooted in countless hours spent in the chapel. Together, we studied scripture, shared our struggles, and prayed.

Smitty had a way of explaining God’s Word that made it come alive and his constructive criticism pushed me to dig deeper – not just to read but to *apply* what I learned. He wasn’t just teaching me, he was walking alongside me as a Brother in Christ.

As I prepared for my parole board hearing, Smitty became one of my greatest supporters. I would write and rewrite my statements, pouring my heart onto paper and then read every word to him.

Smitty wasn't afraid to be honest, offering constructive feedback that was exactly what I needed. He challenged me to be clear, authentic, and intentional in expressing my growth and transformation. His guidance didn't just shape my words – it shaped my understanding of who I was becoming.

Preparing for the board was one of the most daunting tasks I'd faced in prison. It forced me to confront my past, articulate my accountability, and outline my vision for the future. Smitty's encouragement gave me confidence in my ability to present my case and his belief in me was a reflection of the belief I was learning to have in myself.

Our friendship didn't end when I walked out of those prison gates in 2021. Smitty and I stayed in touch – texting, calling, and even video chatting. The connection we built in those chapel walls extended far beyond them.

Recently, he told me something that humbled me deeply. "I learned a lot from you," he said. To hear those words from someone I admired so much helped me realize the beauty of God's design. God had used us both to help each other in ways we might not otherwise have realized.

Our relationship is a testament to the way God works through people, bringing them together at the right time for a purpose greater than either could achieve alone.

Smitty helped me find strength, clarity, and direction when I needed it most, but I'm grateful to know that God used me to bless Smitty also.

That's how it's supposed to be – a mutual exchange of encouragement, growth, and faith.

Through Smitty, I learned that transformation isn't something you do alone; it's something God orchestrates, often through the people He places in your life. I'll always be thankful for the time we spent together in that chapel and for the continued friendship we share today.

Growth doesn't stop at one moment, one decision, or even at one friendship. It's a journey – one that doesn't end when the prison gates finally open.

Chapter 32: Freedom of the Soul

The idea of freedom meant something very different to me by the time I reached the final years of my sentence. For decades, I had believed that freedom was about physical release – walking out of those prison gates and reentering a world without walls.

But as my faith deepened and my heart changed, I began to understand a much greater truth – true freedom isn't about where you are; it's about what's happening inside you.

This realization was the result of years of wrestling with my past, my identity, and the lies I had once believed about who I was. Through the steady work of God's Grace and the influence of people like Chris, Michael, and Smitty, I began to see that the chains I carried weren't just the ones put on me by the justice system. They were the chains of anger, shame, and guilt, chains I had built myself, one bad choice at a time.

As I allowed God to break those chains, I began to experience a freedom I had never known.

Freedom of the soul didn't mean life suddenly became easy. The challenges of prison life were still there – the politics, the constant need to navigate relationships, and the daily grind of a system designed to strip away individuality. As my faith grew, those challenges began to feel smaller. They didn't define me anymore. My circumstances were no longer my prison because I had discovered a peace that surpassed understanding.

One of the clearest moments when I felt this freedom came during a Bible study session in that small chapel library. Smitty and I had been talking about Paul's letters, particularly his time in prison.

Paul wrote about joy and contentment even while he was chained, and for the first time, those words resonated deeply in me. I realized that if Paul could find freedom and purpose in the midst of imprisonment, so could I. His letters became a road map for my own journey, teaching me that the power of God isn't dependent on where I am, but on where my heart is.

That shift in perspective changed everything. I began to see prison as a mission field rather than a punishment.

My interactions with others became opportunities to share the Grace I had found. Younger men, often angry and scared like I had once been, started coming to me for advice. I didn't have all the answers, but I shared what I knew – that real freedom comes not from escaping your circumstances, but from allowing God to transform your heart.

As my release date drew closer, I found myself reflecting on the journey that had brought me here. I thought about the boy I had been when I first walked into those gates – eighteen years old, terrified, and carrying more pain than I could understand.

I thought about the man I had been for most of my sentence – angry, bitter, and lost. Then I thought about who I am now or who I had become. I wasn't perfect and I still had so much to learn, but I was free. Truly free.

The chains that had held me for so long were gone, replaced by a peace and purpose I had never known before.

The most surprising part of this freedom was the way it prepared me for life after prison.

For years, I had heard men talk about the fear of reentry – the anxiety of stepping into a world that had moved on without them. But I didn't feel that fear. I felt excitement, gratitude, and readiness.

I knew that the freedom I had found wasn't tied to my circumstances and because of that, I knew I could face whatever challenges lay ahead.

As the countdown to my release began, I spent more and more time in prayer, asking God to prepare me for the next chapter of my life. I didn't know exactly what it would look like, but I trusted that He had a plan. After all, He had carried me this far – through the darkest moments of my life, through transformation, and into freedom. I knew He wouldn't abandon me now.

Freedom of the soul is a gift that cannot be earned – only received. It is inherent.

It's the kind of freedom that allows you to walk through life with hope and trust, even when the road is hard. It's the kind of freedom that turns prison walls into stepping stones and past mistakes into testimonies of grace. And it's the kind of freedom that I knew I would carry with me, no matter where life took me next.

Because soon, I would have to face the test of that freedom in the real world.

Chapter 33: Stepping Out

The day I walked out of prison was nothing like I had imagined it would be. For years, I had dreamed about this moment – how it would feel, what I would do first, the emotions that would flood me. But nothing could have prepared me for the overwhelming rush of reality that hit as I stepped beyond the gates, beyond the world I had known for nearly three decades.

I had been gone for so long that the outside world felt foreign. The sky seemed too open, the air too fresh. Every sound was amplified – the hum of cars, the chatter of people, the rustling of trees. It was freedom but it was also unfamiliar and unsettling. All of my preparation could not fully bridge the gap between who I had been and who I needed to become.

I was being given an opportunity to prove that I was more than my past, more than the number attached to my name in the prison system. I knew the world hadn't stopped moving while I had been behind bars. The weight of that truth settled on me as I took my first steps into this new life.

The changes in the world were almost overwhelming. Technology was everywhere – smartphones, touchscreens, self-checkouts – things I had never experienced firsthand. Even the simplest tasks, like ordering food or using a debit card, felt like a test. It was humbling to realize that while I had grown in so many ways, I still had so much to learn.

Thankfully, I wasn't alone. My support system, the people who had stood by me, encouraged me, and prayed for me were waiting.

My family, friends, and mentors had helped prepare me for this transition and now they were here to walk alongside me as I stepped into a world that had once seemed unreachable.

One of the first people I called was Smitty. Our friendship had carried across the prison walls and now, through phone calls and messages, we continued to support each other. He had been there in some of my darkest moments and now he was celebrating this new chapter with me.

Adjusting to life outside wasn't just about learning how to function in society again; it was about proving to myself that I could live in alignment with the man I had become.

The politics and rules of prison were no longer my reality, but that didn't mean old temptations and mindsets weren't waiting for me beyond the gates. I had to be intentional in choosing my path, in staying true to the commitments I had made to myself and to God.

Finding work was one of the first challenges. I had never held a real job before – at least, not one where I had to fill out applications and explain the nearly three decades of my absence. But I wasn't looking for a handout. I was ready to work, to build something new, and to contribute to the world-

Each day was a lesson in patience. Some things felt natural, like reconnecting with loved ones, but other things, like navigating social situations, handling responsibilities, or even just standing in a crowded store, felt overwhelming.

The world was fast and I had been living in a place where time crawled. Despite the challenges, I felt something I hadn't in a long time – Purpose.

My story wasn't over, and I wasn't just here to exist, I was here to make a difference. The years I had spent growing, changing, and preparing weren't wasted. They had been shaping me for what was to come.

Stepping out of prison wasn't just about leaving a place; it was about stepping into who I was meant to be. The real journey was just beginning and as I soon learned, freedom comes with its own set of battles.

Chapter 34: A New Foundation

When I stepped out of prison in 2021, I thought the hardest part of my journey was behind me. I had survived the darkness, done the work to transform my life, and now had the chance to start fresh.

What I didn't realize then, was that freedom doesn't just mean walking outside of prison walls; it means knowing your worth, setting boundaries, and refusing to accept less than you deserve. In that, I still had a lot to learn.

In August 2021, I entered a relationship I should have never been in. Her name was Carey, and from the start, there were red flags – manipulation, lies, and constant chaos. But I stayed. Deep down, I still believed I wasn't worthy of something better.

After my parole ended in May 2022, I moved in with her. Her home wasn't a place of peace; it was full of yelling and dysfunction.

The hardest part was her five-year-old son, Levi. I saw myself in him – a kid trying to survive in a world that wasn't safe. In some ways, I stayed as much for him as I did for her.

I left Carey four times. Each time I returned home, the weight lifted – until the loneliness crept back in and pulled me back. I convinced myself a toxic relationship was better than no relationship. I told myself if I tried harder, things would get better. They didn't.

Looking back, the signs were there from day one. On our first date, she walked out of the restaurant mid-meal because of something I said. That should have been enough. Instead, I chased her, fought to keep her, and accepted behavior I never should have tolerated – all because I thought that was what I deserved.

The truth was, I had done the work to change my life, but I still didn't see myself differently. I still carried the fear of letting people down, of failing again, of being alone.

I stayed because I didn't want to disappoint anyone, but in doing so, I was disappointing myself.

For three years I lived in that whirlwind, convincing myself that this is just how life is. I ignored the fact that I had spent decades in prison, dreaming of peace, only to walk into another kind of prison – one built with emotional chains instead of steel bars.

I was still learning that just surviving isn't the same as truly living. I couldn't build a real foundation for my life while standing in the ruins of a relationship that was never meant for me.

But I was getting closer to realizing that the foundation I needed had to be built *by* me. It would take time, pain, and another chance encounter to finally pull me out of the cycle. At that moment, I was trapped, holding onto something that was only holding me back.

The moment I walked away, everything changed.

Chapter 35: Becoming the Light

By the time I walked away from that toxic relationship, three years had gone by. Three years of emotional turmoil, self-doubt, and ignoring every sign that tried to tell me I deserved better.

Growth isn't always about what we gain; it's about what we learn to let go of.

For so long, I had been looking for love, acceptance, and a place to belong. I had dedicated years to learning how to be a better man, yet I still struggled to see my own worth. Once I broke free of that cycle, everything began to shift.

I was still married to Carey when I met Tina. It was nothing like I imagined meeting the person who would change my life, but God has his ways.

At first, I didn't know what to make of her. She was strong, independent, and had a fire in her spirit that I wasn't used to. She wasn't someone I could manipulate and she wasn't someone who would accept less than she deserved. In many ways, she was everything Carey wasn't.

I didn't leave my marriage for a relationship with Tina. I left because I had finally realized I couldn't keep living in a way that contradicted everything I had fought to become. Meeting Tina helped me see what was possible when love is built on mutual respect and shared purpose, as opposed to toxicity and control.

For the first time in my life, I wasn't just trying to survive. I was learning how to live.

As I stepped into this new season, I learned that living outside prison didn't mean my struggles were over. The world outside had its own challenges. Finding a career was proving to be a big one. I wanted to build something stable for myself, something that gave me purpose and security.

My first attempt was to become an insurance salesman, but my background disqualified me. Then, I looked into becoming a nurse. Again, my past was an immediate roadblock. I refused to let it stop me, so I pursued an administrator course to run the RCFE (Residential Care Facility for the Elderly) that Tina and I were working to open. I completed the course only to find out afterward that my record prevented me from being certified.

Each rejection felt like a punch to the gut. I had done my time and had rebuilt myself from the ground up, and still, society held my past against me. It was frustrating, discouraging, and at times, made me question why I was even trying.

Having a career is one of the biggest factors in staying free, yet so many of us who have served time in prison are blocked from opportunities that could keep us on the right path.

I refused to give up and kept searching and finding ways around the roadblocks. Tina stepped up. She took the administrator courses and got certified so we could pursue our dream of opening the RCFE. We had a vision and even if I couldn't lead it in the way I had originally planned, we would make it work.

Having spent nearly three decades incarcerated, my credit history was nonexistent. Banks and lenders didn't care about how much I had changed, all they saw was a blank credit file and a risk. Securing the funding was another uphill battle.

Through every disappointment, I held onto something I had learned – God's plans are always better than my own.

If He had brought me this far, had broken my chains and led me into a new life, then I had to trust that He would provide. Even when doors closed and I felt like I was hitting a wall, I reminded myself that my story was far from over.

Through it all, Tina was by my side, reminding me of my worth and keeping me grounded. She didn't just believe in my potential, she saw it in action. Together, we continued to push forward, entrusting everything to God.

Becoming the light isn't just about overcoming the past. It is about standing firm in one's faith, knowing that even when the world tells you no, God has already written your Yes. In the midst of that journey, I discovered something even more powerful than perseverance.

I discovered love.

Chapter 36: A Love That Endures

When I finally found real love, or when real love finally found me, I almost didn't recognize it. After all of the dysfunction, manipulation and believing I had to fight to keep someone in my life, love had become something I associated with struggle. Meeting Tina taught me that real love isn't something you chase – it's something you build.

I hadn't expected her. I hadn't expected anything, really. After everything I had been through, I was just beginning to heal and to understand my worth. From the moment she entered my life, something felt different.

She saw me – not just the man I had been or the mistakes I had made, but the man I had become and the man I was still working to be.

Being strong, independent, and unapologetically herself, Tina had her own dreams and her own purpose. She wasn't looking for someone to complete her. She was looking for someone who would walk beside her. I had never experienced that kind of partnership before and at first, I didn't know how to accept it.

I had always equated love with sacrifice – giving up parts of yourself to keep someone else happy. With Tina, I learned that love isn't supposed to be painful and it isn't supposed to leave you questioning your worth or wondering if you're enough.

Real love strengthens you; it pushes you to be better and gives you the courage to keep moving forward. Being in love with Tina didn't require me to shrink; it allowed me to grow.

We started as friends. Both of us were guarded, coming from pasts that had shaped us in ways we were still unpacking. Over time, trust was built; not through grand gestures or forced promises, but through consistency, honesty, and a shared vision for the future.

Our love wasn't about filling a void; it was about building something solid.

We each faced our own struggles and obstacles, but for the first time, I was in a relationship where I didn't feel alone in the fight. She stood beside me, not as someone I had to prove myself to, but as someone who believed in me before I even fully believed in myself.

Together, we built something more than just a relationship – we built a partnership in a shared mission. Our dream of opening an assisted living facility wasn't just about business; it was about service and about giving people the dignity and care they deserve.

Our partnership was about taking everything we had been through – our individual struggles, our pasts, our lessons – and turning them into something that could impact others in a meaningful way.

For the first time in my life, I understood what it meant to have a love that endures. A love that wasn't based on fear or obligation, but on respect, faith, and shared purpose.

Tina wasn't just the woman I loved, she was the person who reminded me that I was worthy of love in the first place.

This wasn't the kind of love that burned out quickly or left scars in its wake. This was the kind of love that built something lasting; something I had never known, but now couldn't imagine living without.

As I embraced this love and stood on the foundation of faith, redemption, and purpose, I began to see my life for what it truly was – not a story of division, but one of transformation.

Chapter 37: Unbroken Bonds

My life is divided into two parts – who I was before and who I have become. The more I reflect, the more I realize that my journey isn't about division; it's about transformation and about how every experience, every mistake, and every hardship became part of the foundation for something greater.

The bonds that once held me were chains – chains of addiction, violence, anger, and regret. These chains kept me locked in cycles of destruction, convincing me that there was no way out. But now, the bonds that define me are unbroken – not because they are unshakable, but because they are built on something real. These are the bonds that have carried me through the darkest valleys and into the light of a life I never thought possible.

I think about the people God placed in my path, each one arriving at just the right time. Chris, who challenged me to see myself clearly; Mike, whose faith reminded me that grace is real; Smitty, who became a brother in Christ, guiding me deeper into the Word.

And then...Tina, the woman who stands beside me as I build my future on the foundation of everything I have learned. Each of them, in their own way, has helped me break the chains of my past and replace them with something stronger. Something unbreakable.

Unbroken bonds are not about perfection; they are about resilience. They are about standing firm even when life shakes you, about choosing faith over fear, about refusing to be defined by the worst moments of your life.

For years, I believed that my story ended in a prison cell, that I would never know freedom, never know love, never know what it meant to truly live. But God had a different plan. He took everything I thought was lost and used it to create something new.

I'm not the same man I was and I will never be that man again.

The journey is ongoing. Every day, I wake up with the choice to keep walking this path – to live with integrity, to serve others, and to let my story be a testimony of God's ability to redeem even the most broken lives.

I don't take a single moment for granted. The freedom I have now isn't just about walking outside of prison walls; it's about the peace in my heart, the purpose in my steps, and the unbroken bonds that will carry me through whatever comes next.

This is my story, and it's only the beginning.

Epilogue

Chapter 38: The Other Side

What I Now Understand About My Past Choices...

I have spent a lot of time sitting with my past; not just remembering it, but really sitting with it – walking back through the wreckage, looking it in the face and listening to the pain I tried to drown out for so many years. I can see things now that I couldn't see when I was in the middle of the storm.

I used to believe my choices defined me; that the worst things I did were the final word on who I was. I wore shame like a skin – tight, suffocating, and impossible to shed. I told myself that once you crossed a certain line, you couldn't come back. But I was wrong.

What I understand now is that my choices weren't just rebellion – they were reaction. They were survival. They were a way of taking control in a life where I felt powerless; a way to be seen, even if it was through destruction.

I didn't just wake up one day wanting to hurt people; I woke up angry, lost, scared, and confused. And I had no words for any of it. So I lashed out. I numbed myself and I ran.

In running, I hurt people who didn't deserve it. I broke trust. I fractured relationships. I gave away pieces of myself, thinking they didn't matter.

But they did matter and so did the people I hurt. That's something I had to face, not with excuses but with truth.

The truth is, I let my pain become my identity. I believed I was too far gone to be anything else, so I lived like it. But that is *not* who I am.

I know that now – not because I figured it out on my own, but because God met me in the middle of my mess and told me something different. He didn't speak in thunder or rage. He came through the silence and through the tears I finally let fall, and through the moments I couldn't lie to myself anymore.

He reminded me that who I was created to be had never been erased – just buried.

That's what the other side is for me. It's not about forgetting the past; it's about no longer being chained to it. It's about seeing clearly – maybe for the first time – that every broken step brought me to this place of healing. It's where the shame doesn't speak louder than the grace. It's where I can finally say – *I'm not that person anymore. But I remember him and I know why he broke.*

To anyone reading this who feels stuck in who they used to be – you are not alone and you're not finished. You might be in the middle of your storm right now, thinking you'll never make it out. I'm here to tell you – *you can.*

It starts with facing the truth and trusting that redemption isn't for the perfect; it's for the surrendered.

"Therefore, if anyone is in Christ, he is a new creation. The old has passed away; behold, the new has come."

—2 Corinthians 5:17

Chapter 39: Launch Point

How I Now View Family, Trauma, and Faith...

There was a time when I blamed everything on my family – the chaos, the silence, and the weight I carried. I saw my parents through the eyes of a wounded child – angry at the yelling, confused by the withdrawal, aching for attention I didn't know how to ask for.

For a long time, I let that pain justify my rebellion. I told myself – *If they had been better, I would've turned out different.*

But healing has a way of softening judgment. It doesn't erase what happened, but it changes how you carry it. Now, I see my parents for who they were – two human beings, doing their best with what they were given. I don't excuse the harm, but I no longer hold it as a weapon.

My dad – who disappeared into the garage – was trying to escape his own pain. My mom – who tried to hold everything together – was tired and stretched thin. She was not heartless. And my sister? She was surviving also – just in a different way.

Trauma has a ripple effect. It passes through generations like an echo no one knows how to quiet, but someone has to break the pattern.

For me, that someone is the man I chose to become on the other side of it. It started with surrender – not the kind the world teaches, not weakness, not giving up – but surrendering to something and someone bigger than myself – **God.**

I used to hear the word “faith” and think it meant following rules or pretending to be something you’re not. But that’s not faith.

Faith is raw; it’s real; it’s waking up in a prison cell with nothing and realizing you’re still worth something. Faith is crying out to a God you’re not even sure will listen and being met with mercy instead of judgment.

That’s what changed me. Not religion and not performance. Presence. *God’s Presence.*

He didn’t erase my past; He met me in it.

He showed me that my pain had a pattern and that He had the power to rewrite the narrative. He didn’t tell me to forget my story; He told me to use it.

From that place – broken, but no longer lost – I launched. I launched into forgiveness, into restoration, and into faith that wasn’t just for Sunday mornings; but for every sleepless night, every memory I had to make peace with, and every lie I had to unlearn.

I don’t see my family the same anymore. I see them as the people God used to shape me, even through the hurt. I love them more now than I ever could have before. I love from a place that is no longer demanding something in return.

I see faith, not as a crutch, but as the foundation. It's what keeps me standing when the weight tries to crush me. It's what reminds me – *you don't have to carry what Jesus already died to take.*

This chapter isn't just a reflection. It's a launch point – for you, too.

*“The Lord is close to the brokenhearted and
saves those who are crushed in spirit.”*

—Psalm 34:18

Chapter 40: Unshackled Perspective

The Wisdom Gained from the Pain and the Process...

The kind of wisdom I carry today didn't come from a textbook. It didn't come from lectures or programs or some motivational slogan on a wall. It came from pain, from silence, and from staring at the ceiling in a cold cell night after night, wondering if I'd ever get a second chance – or if I even deserved one.

Some lessons you can only learn in the darkness.

There's a kind of clarity that comes when the noise is stripped away; when you have no more distractions, no more people to impress, and no more lies left to tell yourself. That's where I learned who I was. That's where I began to see what I had become – and what I could still be.

Pain is a mirror. It doesn't lie. And if you're brave enough to look into it, it'll show you things comfort never could.

I learned that strength isn't loud – it's honest. The most courageous thing I ever did wasn't surviving prison or confronting violence. It was letting myself feel. Letting myself cry. Letting God into places I had barricaded for years.

I learned that forgiveness isn't weakness – it's freedom. And I needed forgiveness – not just from others, but toward others. I forgave my father, I forgave the people who failed me, and I forgave myself.

Through it all, I learned the difference between reputation and character. Reputation is what you build in front of people; character is who you are when there's no one left to applaud or accuse.

That was the breaking point – the shift – when I stopped trying to prove something and started to become someone.

An Unshackled perspective isn't just about being free from chains – it's about being free from the mindset that built the chains in the first place.

I used to chase control. Now, I seek surrender.

I used to numb the pain. Now, I listen to it.

I used to run from the truth. Now, I tell it.

Even when it costs me. Especially when it costs me.

This perspective didn't come easy. It came through fire, through failure, and through Grace that I never could have earned.

If you're still in the middle of your process, let me say this. Wisdom isn't born from having it all figured out; it's born from facing what you'd rather avoid, from digging into the mess, and from choosing to learn from it instead of repeating it.

*“Not only so, but we also glory in our sufferings,
because we know that suffering produces perseverance –
perseverance, character – and character, hope.*

—Romans 5:3–4

That's what I found in the process –

Perseverance, Character, Hope, and above all...Purpose.

Chapter 41: Lessons in the Ashes

What the Pain Revealed About Who I Really Am...

Everything that once gave me identity had to be burned away before I could finally see who I really was. For so long, I clung to things I thought made me somebody – my street reputation, the fear I inspired, the survival stories. Even the pain became a kind of badge. If I couldn't be loved, I would be respected or feared.

But all of that – every mask, every layer of armor, every false identity – was built on pain, which is a brutal foundation. So when life burned it all down and I was left in the ashes of my choices, I thought it was the end. What I didn't realize at the time was that it was actually the beginning.

You see – we avoid the ashes, we avoid the fire, and we avoid discomfort like it's something to be ashamed of. But I've learned that discomfort is sacred. It is not the enemy; it's the invitation. So embrace the discomfort, knowing that you are being forged for something greater.

When you finally sit in it – when you stop running, stop numbing, stop pretending – you make room for God to speak. What He whispers in that space doesn't sound like judgment. It sounds like *Truth!*

I started to see that I was *not* the worst thing I had ever done. I wasn't my reputation. I wasn't what people said about me nor what I said about myself in my lowest moments.

I was someone God had never stopped pursuing, even though I wasn't chasing Him.

That's the thing – my whole life, I was always chasing something – approval, numbness, control, identity. But the chase was exhausting, and no matter how fast or far I ran, I could never catch what I was after, because it was never clearly defined.

Now I understand – I was created to chase God and He is the only One who can truly satisfy.

Everything else left me hungry, empty, and burned out. Once I stopped chasing shadows and turned toward the Light, I finally found rest – not perfection and not comfort in the way the world defines it, but peace – real peace. In that peace, I started to learn who I actually am.

You can't know yourself fully until you know the One who created you. You can't understand the design without knowing the Designer.

In the ashes, I met Him and there I met myself. Not the version built on defense mechanisms or damage, but the Son He always knew; the one He never gave up on, the one He saw beneath all the wreckage.

Now, I don't despise the fire and I don't hate the ashes. It was there, in the stillness, in the wreckage and ruin, that God rebuilt me.

And what He built is rooted, unshackled, and real.

*“He gives beauty for ashes, the oil of joy for mourning,
the garment of praise for the spirit of heaviness...”*

—Isaiah 61:3

Chapter 42: Your Turn Now

A Final Message to the Reader...

If you're holding this book; I want you to know something. *You're not reading this by accident!* Maybe you're in a place right now where everything feels like it's breaking. Maybe you're stuck in patterns you swore you'd never repeat. Maybe you're tired, angry, or numb. Maybe you've been chasing things for years – approval, love, control, escape – and you're still empty.

I know that place. I lived there for years, and I want to tell you the truth that no one told me when I needed it most.

You are not too far gone.

You're not too broken, too angry, nor too ashamed.

You're not beyond healing or hope.

The negative things people say to you is a reflection of who *they* are – not of who *you* are. Something has to change and that something isn't your past – *it's your posture.*

You must stop running. You have to stop numbing and performing and pretending. You have to face the pain. And I won't lie to you – it's going to hurt.

At first, it'll feel like everything is falling apart, but what's actually happening is that the lies are breaking off. The masks are cracking and beneath all of that is someone you may have forgotten – the *Real* you.

The one who was made on purpose.
The one who still matters.
The one who's been loved all along by a God who
has never stopped chasing you.

So if you're tired of the weight...lay it down.
If you're tired of the running...be still.
If you're tired of the noise...let the silence speak.

God is not looking for your performance. He's
waiting for your surrender.

This is your moment. It's your turn now.

*“For I know the plans I have for you,”
declares the Lord, “plans to prosper you
and not to harm you, plans to give you a
future and a hope.”*

—Jeremiah 29:11

Afterword

If you've made it to these final pages, thank you—for leaning in, for walking with me through the pain, the loss, the chaos, and the grace. You've seen the cracks in my life, the places where I thought nothing good could ever grow. And you've seen what God can do when we stop hiding the damage and let Him work in the open.

This is not the end of my story. I am still learning, still growing, still being shaped by His hand. But the man who began this journey is not the man who writes these words today. The chains that once defined me have been broken, and in their place is a freedom I never thought possible—not because I earned it, but because He gave it.

My hope is that something in these pages stirred something in you. Maybe it gave you permission to be honest about your own pain. Maybe it reminded you that you are not too far gone. Or

maybe it planted the smallest seed of faith that change is possible, no matter how long you've been stuck.

If there's one thing I want you to remember, it's this: God is not afraid of your mess. He is not waiting for you to get cleaned up before you come to Him. He is the One who cleans you, restores you, and makes you new.

The cracks in your life are not the end—they are the places where His light can shine through. Don't cover them up. Let them tell your story. Let them lead someone else to freedom.

—Chris K.

About the Author

Chris Kelly spent twenty-seven years behind prison walls, but his story is not one of defeat—it is one of redemption. Once caught in a cycle of addiction, violence, and self-destruction, Chris's life was transformed by the grace of God. Today, he uses the same honesty that once fueled his rebellion to speak truth, hope, and freedom into the lives of others.

Through his work with *Unshackled Truth*, Chris reaches into prisons, recovery homes, and broken communities with a message that healing is possible, purpose can be found, and no life is beyond God's reach. His memoir, *The Cracks Beneath the Surface*, shares the raw, unfiltered journey from a hardened heart to a life restored, offering readers both

a mirror to see themselves and a map toward freedom.

Chris now writes, speaks, and mentors with the same passion he once devoted to destruction—only now it is for building lives. He lives in California with his fiancée, Tina, where they are preparing to open an assisted living facility and continue their work in faith-based recovery.

You can connect with Chris at:

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Call to Action

If this book spoke to you — if you saw pieces of your own story in my brokenness, or caught a glimpse of hope in God's grace — don't let it end here.

Pick up the Word. Start with John's Gospel. Read it slowly. Ask God to meet you in its pages.

Pray honestly. You don't need fancy words. Just talk to Him like you would a friend.

Reflect deeply. Write down what God shows you. Truth becomes clearer when we wrestle with it on paper.

Don't walk alone. Find a local church, recovery group, or community that will remind you of God's truth when lies get loud.

Live unshackled. Don't wait for perfect conditions — step into the freedom Jesus already paid for.

And if you're ready to take the next step, I invite you to join me and others walking this same journey at **Unshackled Truth Media**. Together, we can break the cycles, heal from the pain, and live for God's glory.

Visit: **UnshackledTruthMedia.com**

Follow: **@UnshackledTruth** on TikTok, YouTube, and Instagram

This isn't the end — it's your launch point.

The cracks don't define you. Christ does.

The Cracks Beneath the Surface

*Unmasking the Lies, Confronting the Pain,
and Finding God in the Midst of It All*

